

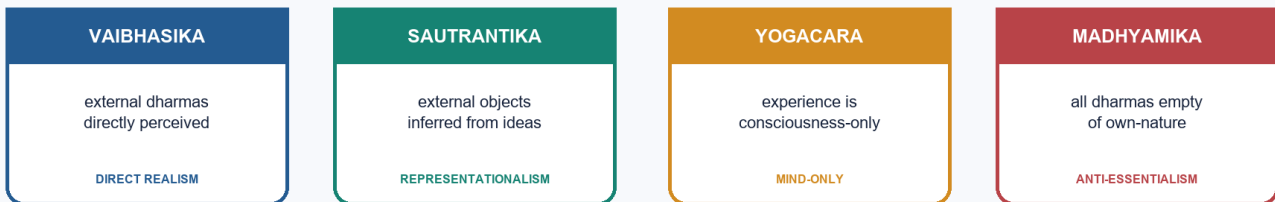
Schools of Buddhism

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

BUDDHISM: DEPENDENT PROCESS, NO SUBSTANCE



FOUR SCHOOL ANSWERS TO WHAT IS ULTIMATELY REAL?



Continuity is causal (santana), not substantial; conventional truth preserves ethics and practice.

Concept map for revision; arrows show derivation, not a chronological history of schools.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Schools of Buddhism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper I - Indian Philosophy · philosophy-paper-i-indian-philosophy-03 **Generation:** g2, 21 August 2026 · **Supersedes:** philosophy-paper-i-indian-philosophy-03: legacy-v1: g1 · **Approval:** pending explicit topic approval **Evidence discipline:** doctrine and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. Model answers are independent pedagogic practice, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	13
Core diagnostic MCQs	40
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	48
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20)
Consolidated register parts	12 (A-L)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Layered Simple/Core/Exam/Rapid material	Basic Learning Session	Complete eight-subtopic sequence retained
Layered Advanced material	Optional Advanced	Every advanced synthesis retained after practice
Canonical owner	Reconciled through layered session	Causation, impermanence, no-self, four schools, epistemology and liberation retained
Legacy solved workbook	PYQs and Answer Practice	All thirteen solved PYQs preserved and improved
Premium diagnostic replacement	MCQs / Remediation	Legacy 24+8 set expanded to genuine 40+8 with strict rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six solved non-PYQ models replace the legacy three-model set
Consolidated register	Final section	A-L retrieval framework covers the complete printed syllabus

Answer-worthiness. *Pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*, *nairātmyavāda*, *nirvāṇa* and the four-school contrast are **CORE SYLLABUS**. Buddhist *pramāṇa* theory, *apoha*, *avyākṛta* questions and controlled cross-school objections are **CORE SUPPORTING DEPTH** where they sharpen PYQ answers. Heritage diplomacy is an application anchor, never doctrinal proof.

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

Heritage diplomacy is an application anchor, never doctrinal proof.

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Buddhist pramāṇa theory, apoha, avyākṛta questions and controlled cross-school objections are CORE SUPPORTING DEPTH where they sharpen PYQ answers.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda, nairātmyavāda, nirvāṇa and the four-school contrast are CORE SYLLABUS.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Heritage diplomacy is an application anchor, never doctrinal proof.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda, nairātmyavāda, nirvāṇa and the four-school contrast are CORE SYLLABUS.

Contemporary-anchor discipline

FACT: **Fact:** The High Commission of India in Colombo reported the public exposition of the Devnimori Buddha relics at Gangaramaya Temple from 4-10 February 2026, presenting it as cultural and spiritual engagement through shared Buddhist heritage. **ANALYSIS:** **Inference:** The event can frame Buddhism as a living civilizational language, but answers must derive doctrine from dependent origination, momentariness, no-self, emptiness, consciousness and liberation.

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Learner-v2 roadmap

SUFFERING HAS CONDITIONS

->

CONDITIONED THINGS ARE IMPERMANENT

->

NO PERMANENT SELF OWNS THE STREAM

->

SCHOOLS DISAGREE ABOUT EXTERNAL OBJECTS, CONSCIOUSNESS AND EMPTINESS

->

INSIGHT BREAKS CRAVING AND CONDITIONED SUFFERING

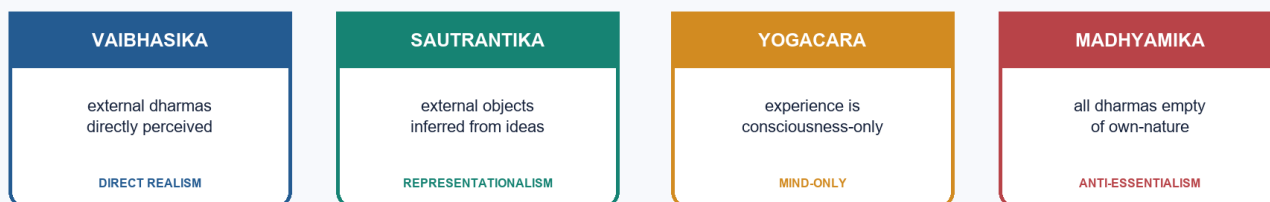
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NIRVĀṆA

BUDDHISM: DEPENDENT PROCESS, NO SUBSTANCE



FOUR SCHOOL ANSWERS TO WHAT IS ULTIMATELY REAL?



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Concept map for revision; arrows show derivation, not a chronological history of schools.

Buddhist dependent process

Master distinction gateway

Doctrine	Central question	Exam-safe formulation
<i>Pratītyasamutpāda</i>	How do suffering and phenomena arise?	through causes and conditions
<i>Kṣaṇikavāda</i>	What is the temporal nature of the causally real?	causally efficacious reals are momentary
<i>Nairātmyavāda</i>	Is there an enduring owner of the stream?	no permanent self beyond the aggregates
<i>Śūnyatā</i>	Do dependently arisen things possess own-nature?	they are empty of independent <i>svabhāva</i>

Master verdict: Buddhism is a family of anti-substantialist, causally ordered and soteriological systems; its schools range from realism through consciousness-only analysis to radical emptiness.

How to use this layered session

Each logical subtopic follows the Philosophy five-layer sequence:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	Plain-language visual gateway
2. CORE UPSC	Complete retained doctrine, arguments and examples
3. ADVANCED	Objections, replies, comparisons and refinements
4. EXAM APPLICATION	Verified PYQ routing and answer structure
5. RAPID REVISION	Traps, recall spines and mastery preparation

Source audit: the canonical Buddhism knowledge file and complete 2018-2025 PYQ bank were checked. Local OCR-searchable chapters in Chatterjee-Datta (Buddhist chapter beginning at file page 149) and C. D. Sharma (file pages 67-81) were directly inspected. The February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition was rechecked through the High Commission of India in Colombo and is used only as a contemporary conceptual anchor. Qdrant was not required.

Preservation note: every substantive section of the earlier complete session is retained. The new material adds simple gateways and explicit layers without replacing the original depth.

Progress: 1 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Dependent Origination: The Causal and Soteriological Core

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - suffering is a process, not a fate

IGNORANCE

|
conditions craving and clinging

|
becoming, birth, ageing and death

Change the conditions -> change the result.

In simple words: Buddhism asks what keeps suffering happening. If suffering arises because conditions cooperate, it is neither eternal nor imposed by fate. Remove the sustaining conditions and the process can cease.

First idea	Easy meaning
<i>Pratītyasamutpāda</i>	Things arise and cease through conditions
Twelve <i>nidānas</i>	Detailed cycle from ignorance to ageing and death
Middle way	Neither eternal substance nor sheer nothingness
Soteriological point	A conditioned problem can be interrupted

Memory line: because suffering is dependently produced, liberation is causally possible.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS = existential frame

|
+- *duḥkha* has a cause -> dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*)
|
| +- whatever arises dependently lacks self-existence (*svabhāva*)
| +- whatever is conditioned is impermanent
| +- what is called "person" is only a dependently arisen aggregate
|
+- *KṢAṆIKAVĀDA*: all conditioned reals are momentary
+- *NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA*: no permanent *ātman*/self
+- *NIRVĀṆA*: cessation of the causal process of suffering

FOUR SCHOOLS

Vaibhāṣika -> Sautrāntika -> Yogācāra/Vijñānavāda -> Mādhyamika/Śūnyavāda
direct realism representationalism consciousness-only emptiness of *svabhāva*

ANALYSIS: Exam key: In Buddhism, the three syllabus terms are not separate islands. Dependent origination yields impermanence; impermanence undermines substantial selfhood; no-self reshapes karma, rebirth and *nirvāṇa*.

1. PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA (*Pratītyasamutpada*) - DEPENDENT ORIGATION

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition:
pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

1.1 Statement

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda** means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.
- FACT: The standard formula, in substance, is: "**imaṣmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imaṣmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati**" - this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases.
- FACT: It is not merely a cosmological thesis. It is the key to the arising of **duḥkha** and therefore the key to its cessation.

1.2 The Four Noble Truths as the frame

- FACT: Buddhism states the problem first: **duḥkha**.
- FACT: It then identifies a causal structure: duḥkha has an origin.
- FACT: Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.
- FACT: Therefore a path is possible.
- ANALYSIS: So dependent origination is the philosophical grammar of the Four Noble Truths. The first truth states the fact of suffering; the second gives its dependent arising; the third gives dependent cessation; the fourth is the practical discipline for breaking the chain.

1.3 The twelve nidānas in order

- FACT: The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the **dvādaśa-nidāna** sequence:
 1. **avidyā** - ignorance
 2. **saṃskāra** - formations/dispositions
 3. **vijñāna** - consciousness
 4. **nāma-rūpa** - name-and-form
 5. **ṣaḍāyatana** - six sense-bases
 6. **sparśa** - contact
 7. **vedanā** - feeling
 8. **trṣṇā** - craving
 9. **upādāna** - clinging/grasping
 10. **bhava** - becoming/existence
 11. **jāti** - birth
 12. **jarā-maraṇa** - old age and death
- FACT: In visual Buddhist pedagogy, this sequence is often represented through the **bhava-cakra** (wheel of becoming), showing how ignorance and craving keep cyclic existence in motion.

1.4 Argument structure

1. FACT: What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.
2. FACT: If a thing were self-existent by its own nature, it would not depend on conditions.
3. FACT: But all conditioned phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions.
4. FACT: Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness; they are dependent processes.
5. ANALYSIS: The existential point is that suffering too is a process, not a metaphysical fate. Therefore it is removable.

1.5 Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through **conditional relations**, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.
- ANALYSIS: It also presupposes that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.

1.6 Distinction: middle way between extremes

- FACT: Buddhism presents dependent origination as the **middle way** between:
 - **śāśvatavāda** - eternalism: some enduring self/substance exists unchanged.
 - **ucchedavāda** - annihilationism: things are sheer nullities or persons are simply obliterated without causal continuity.
- ANALYSIS: Why is this a middle? Because Buddhism denies permanent substance, yet it also denies that phenomena are sheer nothing. What exists does so dependently.

1.7 Example

- ANALYSIS: A flame persists only because wick, oil, oxygen and ignition remain coordinated. Remove the conditions and the flame ceases. Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns. This approximates dependent origination better than the language of substance.

1.8 Objection

- CAUTION: If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately? Does it create an infinite regress of conditions?

1.9 Reply

- FACT: Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible. Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.
- ANALYSIS: UPSC answers should stress that dependent origination is not a failed search for a first cause; it is a diagnosis of dependent becoming.

1.10 How momentariness follows from dependent origination

- FACT: What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.
- FACT: Therefore what is conditioned is **anitya** (impermanent); Buddhist logicians radicalize this into **kṣaṇikavāda**, according to which what is real is momentary.
- ANALYSIS: Thus a 2019-style answer can move from pratītyasamutpāda to kṣaṇikavāda by arguing: the dependently arisen has no independent enduring essence; it is event-like, not substance-like.

1.11 How 2024's "everything is void" and "everything is real" both arise from pratītyasamutpāda

(a) Mādhyamika: dependent origination implies emptiness

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess **svabhāva** (self-being/own-nature).
- FACT: Therefore all dharmas are **śūnya** - empty of independent essence.
- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is what is called empty.
- ANALYSIS: This does **not** mean sheer non-being; it means lack of intrinsic, self-subsistent reality.

(b) Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika: dependent origination implies conditioned reality

- FACT: The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.
- FACT: But instead of inferring emptiness of all dharmas in the Mādhyamika sense, they say: precisely because things arise causally, they are **real as conditioned entities**.
- FACT: Vaibhāṣika treats dharmas as real and directly knowable; Sautrāntika treats them as real though not directly perceived externally.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the same causal thesis can support two ontological emphases: absence of self-nature, or reality of conditioned events.

(c) Distinguishing the two conclusions

School move	What is denied	What is affirmed
Mādhyamika	intrinsic nature (svabhāva)	conventional dependent existence
Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika	eternal substance and self	reality of conditioned dharmas

1.12 Cessation and knowledge

- FACT: Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage; insight into it is release.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore the 2023 question - ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation - should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2018 Q5(b), 10 marks:** derive *śūnyatā* from dependent origination without equating emptiness with non-being.
- **2019 Q7(c), 15 marks** and **2020 Q6(a), 20 marks:** show how dependence and causal change lead to momentariness.
- **2023 Q8(a), 20 marks:** connect ignorance of the chain to suffering and insight into the chain to cessation.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** compare the realist and Mādhyamika conclusions from the same causal doctrine.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Standard pattern: this being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases.
- Twelve links run from ignorance to ageing and death.
- *Pratītyasamutpāda* is causal, existential and soteriological.
- Middle way: causal continuity without permanent substance.
- Trap: dependent origination is not fatalism; conditions can be altered.

Progress: 2 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Kṣaṇikavāda: Momentariness, Causal Efficiency and Continuity

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - the flame is a stream of events

flame 1 -> flame 2 -> flame 3
similar and causally connected
but not one numerically unchanged flame

continuity = series, not permanent substance

In simple words: what looks like one lasting thing may be a rapidly connected sequence. Each moment performs its causal work and gives rise to the next.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Kṣaṇikavāda</i>	Conditioned reality is momentary
<i>Arthakriyā</i>	Capacity to produce an effect
<i>Santāna</i>	Causal continuum
Recognition	Similarity within a stream, according to Buddhism

Memory line: what is real acts; what acts does so in a changing causal moment.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

2. KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (Ksanikavada) - DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

2.1 Statement

- **FACT:** **Kṣaṇikavāda** holds that whatever is real is momentary.
- **FACT:** A standard scholastic formulation runs in substance as: **whatever is truly real is momentary** (*sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam*).
- **ANALYSIS:** The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is evental rather than substantial.

2.2 Argument from causal efficiency (arthakriyākāritva)

Statement

- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva** (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: **sat = arthakriyā-samartha** - the real is what is capable of producing an effect.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda** follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.
- ANALYSIS: This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular) as ultimately real also grounds the thesis **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam** - whatever is real is momentary.

Argument

1. FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for Buddhist analysis.
2. FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either **simultaneously** or **successively**.
3. FACT: If a permanent entity produces its effect all at once, nothing remains for later production; this is the **yaugapadya** (simultaneity) horn.
4. FACT: If it produces effects successively, then it functions differently at different moments; what functions differently is not wholly permanent. This is the **krama** (succession) horn.
5. FACT: If Nyāya says it acts only when auxiliary conditions (**sahakārin**, helper-conditions) are present, the Buddhist reply is the **sahakāri-anapekṣā** dilemma: either the permanent thing already has the power and does not need auxiliaries, or the decisive causal power lies in the changing auxiliaries rather than in the permanent thing.
6. FACT: Therefore a permanent entity cannot coherently be causally efficient.
7. FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary: **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.
- ANALYSIS: It also presupposes that a single unchanged entity cannot have genuinely different causal profiles at different times without ceasing to be unchanged.

Distinction

Issue	FACT: Buddhist logician	FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika opponent
Test of reality	FACT: causal efficacy (arthakriyā)	FACT: substance, quality, action, universal, inherence and absence as categories
Enduring thing	FACT: only a conventional series	FACT: real substance enduring through changing qualities
Effect at different times	FACT: requires momentary causal phases	FACT: explained by auxiliary conditions acting on an enduring substance

Example

- ANALYSIS: A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout. But the seed that has exercised that precise sprout-producing capacity is no longer the same causal phase; the series has advanced.

Objection - Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?
- FACT: Nyāya also uses **pratyabhijñā** (recognition - “this is that same jar”), memory and moral desert to argue that enduring substances and selves are required.

Reply - Buddhist logicians

- FACT: The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant.
- FACT: Recognition is explained through **sādrśya** (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity.

- FACT: Memory and desert are explained through **santāna / santati** (causal continuum), with **ālaya-vijñāna** and **bīja** (seeds) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device.
- ANALYSIS: The Nyāya rejoinder retains force: a mere series seems unable to own memories or deserts unless something owns the series.

2.3 Argument from destruction (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga line)

- FACT: Another line of reasoning holds that destruction does not require a second, separate destroyer added from outside.
- FACT: The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.
- ANALYSIS: Hence things are not first fully stable entities and later destroyed; their transience belongs to what they are.

2.4 Apparent continuity: santāna

- FACT: If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?
- FACT: Buddhism answers through **santāna** - a causal series or stream.
- FACT: Each moment gives rise to the next sufficiently similar moment, producing the appearance of persistence.
- FACT: Standard illustrations are a **flame** or a **stream**: continuity without strict identity.

2.5 Memory and personal identity under momentariness (2021)

Objection - Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: If every mental state perishes instantly, then who remembers a past event?
- FACT: If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

Buddhist replies

1. FACT: **Santāna**: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.
2. FACT: **Pratisandhāna**: reconnection/relinking explains continuity across moments and lives.
3. FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna** in Yogācāra: a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (**bīja**, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential.

Philosophical point

- ANALYSIS: The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

2.6 Karma without a self (2022)

Problem

- FACT: Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

Buddhist answer

- FACT: The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.
- FACT: The relation is **neither identity nor utter difference**.
- ANALYSIS: If it were strict identity, Buddhism would collapse into eternalism; if it were total difference, responsibility would collapse. The doctrine of series protects moral continuity without substantial selfhood.

2.7 Example

- ANALYSIS: One lamp lights another. The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it. Rebirth and karmic fruition are often explained analogically in this way.

2.8 Objection - Nyāya pratyabhijñā argument

- CAUTION: Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

2.9 Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.

- ANALYSIS: The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- Reconstruct *arthakriyākāritva* before stating momentariness.
- Use the simultaneity/succession dilemma and address auxiliary conditions.
- **2021 Q7(b), 15 marks:** explain memory and identity through causal continuity, similarity and seeds, then concede the ownership objection.
- **2022 Q6(a), 20 marks:** apply the same stream model to karma and moral continuity.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Formula: whatever is real is momentary.
- Reality test: causal efficacy.
- Two horns for a permanent cause: simultaneous effects or changing succession.
- Continuity device: *santāna/santati*, not permanent identity.
- Trap: momentariness does not mean causal disconnectedness.

Progress: 3 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Nairātmyavāda: Five Aggregates, Karma and Nirvāṇa Without a Soul

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - person as an organised process

BODY + FEELING + RECOGNITION
+ DISPOSITIONS + CONSCIOUSNESS
↓
v
conventionally called "person"

No extra permanent owner is found.

In simple words: Buddhism does not deny everyday persons. It denies an additional unchanging self behind the five aggregates. The person is a dependently organised causal process.

Aggregate	Easy meaning
<i>Rūpa</i>	Material form
<i>Vedanā</i>	Feeling
<i>Samjñā</i>	Recognition or designation
<i>Samskāra</i>	Dispositions and formations
<i>Vijñāna</i>	Consciousness

Memory line: conventional personhood remains; permanent substance-self is rejected.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

3. NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (Nairatmyavada) - NO-SELF DOCTRINE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

3.1 Statement

- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda** or **anātmavāda** denies a permanent, unchanging ātman behind experience.

- FACT: What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.

3.2 The five skandhas

- FACT: The person is analysed into five **skandhas**:

1. **rūpa** - form/material body
2. **vedanā** - feeling/sensation
3. **saṃjñā** - perception/recognition
4. **saṃskāra** - dispositions/formations
5. **vijñāna** - consciousness

- ANALYSIS: The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

3.3 Chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha)

- FACT: The classic **chariot analogy** argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.
- FACT: Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas.
- ANALYSIS: The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal. It is that the person is conventionally valid but not ultimately self-subsistent.

3.4 Pudgala-nairātmya and dharma-nairātmya (2021)

Pudgala-nairātmya

- FACT: Denial of a permanent personal self (**pudgala**, person).
- FACT: This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.

Dharma-nairātmya

- FACT: Denial that even dharmas possess intrinsic self-nature.
- FACT: This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

School difference

- FACT: **Hīnayāna / early realist schools**: primarily affirm **pudgala-nairātmya**; dharmas are treated as real.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna**: affirms both **pudgala-nairātmya** and **dharma-nairātmya**; neither person nor dharma has svabhāva.

Distinction table

Thesis	What is denied	Who strongly stresses it
Pudgala-nairātmya	enduring person/self	all Buddhism
Dharma-nairātmya	intrinsic nature of dharmas	Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika

3.5 The Puggalavāda foil

- FACT: Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the **Vātsīputrīyas**, proposed a **pudgala** that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.
- FACT: Mainstream Buddhists criticized this as a relapse toward self-theory.
- ANALYSIS: In answers, use Puggalavāda as a foil: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real, but orthodox Buddhist thought refused to answer it by reintroducing a substantial person.

3.6 Triratna and no-self (2022)

Problem

- FACT: If there is no self, who takes refuge in the **Triratna** - Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the **conventional person**, a **prajñapti-puruṣa** or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.

- FACT: Ethical and spiritual practice proceeds at the level of conventional truth without requiring metaphysical ātman.
- ANALYSIS: Thus anātman does not abolish discipline; it purifies it of ego-metaphysics.

3.7 Nirvāṇa

- FACT: **Nirvāṇa** is the cessation of suffering and the extinguishing of the three fires: **rāga** (attachment), **dveṣa** (aversion), and **moha** (delusion).
- FACT: It is not best understood as a substantial place or eternal self-state gained by an entity.
- ANALYSIS: It is the cessation of the very process that produces bondage.

3.8 Is nirvāṇa consistent with kṣaṇikavāda and nairātmyavāda? (2025)

Objection - Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya realist

- FACT: If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?
- FACT: If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?

Reply

1. FACT: The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects.
2. FACT: Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.
3. FACT: It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.
4. ANALYSIS: So consonance exists: no-self removes the false claimant to liberation; momentariness explains why the chain can in fact cease.

Theravāda and Mahāyāna nuance

- FACT: **Theravāda**: emphasizes individual **nibbāna** and the arhat ideal.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna**: emphasizes the bodhisattva ideal and universal liberation.
- FACT: In Nāgārjuna's radical language, **saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms**; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2018 Q6(b), 15 marks** and **2025 Q8(c), 15 marks**: establish compatibility by distinguishing cessation of process from destruction of a permanent self.
- **2020 Q7(b), 15 marks**: use the five aggregates and chariot analogy, then define liberation without importing Vedānta.
- **2021 Q5(d), 10 marks**: distinguish personal no-self from Mahāyāna's no-self of dharmas.
- **2022 Q7(b), 15 marks**: explain how the three jewels guide a path without presupposing an eternal practitioner.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Five aggregates, no sixth permanent owner.
- *Pudgala-nairātmya*: no substantial person.
- *Dharma-nairātmya*: no intrinsic nature in dharmas.
- Karma continues through a causal stream.
- Nirvāṇa is cessation without an eternal possessor.

Progress: 4 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: The Four Schools and Buddhist Arguments Against a Creator

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - four answers to what is ultimately real

VAIBHASIKA	: external dharmas directly known
SAUTRANTIKA	: external dharmas inferred from representations
YOGACARA	: cognitive process, not independent external object
MADHYAMIKA	: no dharma has intrinsic self-nature

In simple words: the schools share impermanence and no-self but disagree about external objects, consciousness and the ultimate status of dharmas.

School	Recall label
Vaibhāṣika	Direct realism
Sautrāntika	Representational or inferential realism
Yogācāra	Consciousness-only analysis
Mādhyamika	Emptiness of intrinsic nature

Memory line: direct object -> inferred object -> cognition-only -> emptiness of every fixed position.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

4. THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

4.1 Vaibhāṣika

- FACT: Usually associated with **Sarvāstivāda** realism.
- FACT: Holds **bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda**: external objects are directly perceived.
- FACT: Affirms **sarvam asti** in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.

Philosophical significance

- ANALYSIS: Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.
- ANALYSIS: It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.

4.2 Sautrāntika

- FACT: Holds **bāhyānumeya-vāda**: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.
- FACT: Rejects the Sarvāstivāda thesis that past and future dharmas exist in the same sense as present ones.
- FACT: Strongly privileges the present moment.

Distinction from Vaibhāṣika

Issue	Vaibhāṣika	Sautrāntika
External object	real	real
How known	directly perceived	inferentially known via representation
Temporal ontology	past-present-future dharmas exist	only present dharmas fully exist

4.3 Yogācāra / Vijñānavāda

Statement

- FACT: Yogācāra advances **vijñaptimātra** or consciousness-only.
- FACT: What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

Key doctrine: ālaya-vijñāna

- FACT: The **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (**bījas**), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

Arguments against external realism

1. FACT: **Dream argument:** dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.
2. FACT: **Atom critique:** if atoms are partless, they cannot combine spatially; if they have parts, they are not ultimate atoms. Hence external atomism is unstable.

Tri-svabhāva (three natures)

- FACT: **parikalpita-svabhāva** - imagined nature
- FACT: **paratantra-svabhāva** - dependent nature
- FACT: **pariniṣpanna-svabhāva** - perfected/consummate nature
- ANALYSIS: These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

4.4 Mādhyamika / Śūnyavāda

Statement

- FACT: Associated especially with **Nāgārjuna**.
- FACT: The central thesis is **śūnyatā** (emptiness): absence of **svabhāva** (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.
- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.

Catuṣkoṭi - the four corners

Corner	Sanskrit	FACT: Basic claim
1	asti	FACT: It is.
2	nāsti	FACT: It is not.
3	asti ca nāsti ca	FACT: It both is and is not.
4	naivāsti naiva nāsti	FACT: It neither is nor is not.

- FACT: **Early / Nikāya use:** the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.
- FACT: **Madhyamaka use:** Nāgārjuna negates all four alternatives when they are applied to things imagined as possessing **svabhāva**.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

Crucial logical nuance - why this is not simple contradiction

- FACT: Madhyamaka negation is best read as **prasajya-pratiṣedha** (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not **paryudāsa-pratiṣedha** (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).
- FACT: The four corners are denied **of things taken as having svabhāva**; once svabhāva is dropped, the denial does not install a fifth positive thesis.
- FACT: Hence Nāgārjuna can claim, in the spirit of the *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, that he has no independent **pratijñā** (thesis) of his own.
- ANALYSIS: This means: "I deny that x has intrinsic nature" is not meant to assert a new metaphysical substrate called emptiness.

Two truths as the anti-nihilist frame

Truth	FACT: Meaning	ANALYSIS: Exam use
saṃvṛti-satya	FACT: Conventional truth: language, persons, karma, compassion and practice function dependently.	ANALYSIS: Prevents Madhyamaka from abolishing ordinary discourse.
paramārtha-satya	FACT: Ultimate truth: no dharma possesses svabhāva.	ANALYSIS: Prevents conventional truth from being mistaken for substance.

- FACT: Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.
- FACT: Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized.
- ANALYSIS: The two-truths doctrine keeps catuṣkoṭi from collapsing into nihilism: conventional functioning is preserved, ultimate intrinsic being is denied.

Objection - Nyāya / Uddyotakara-type and modern irrationalism charge

- FACT: The opponent says: if all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.
- FACT: The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.

Reply - Nāgārjuna and later Madhyamaka

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.
- FACT: The traditional image is that one magically created person (**nirmitaka**) may counteract another magically created person; similarly, empty words may cure empty reifications.
- FACT: The Mādhyamika uses arguments as medicine, not as a new metaphysical substance.
- ANALYSIS: Whether this reply fully succeeds is genuinely debated.
- CAUTION: The **Prāsaṅgika / Svātantrika** split marks this debate internally: **Candrakīrti** is associated with using reductio (**prasaṅga**) without independent syllogisms, while **Bhāvaviveka** allows independent (**svatantra**) inferences in debate.

Śūnyatā is not nihilism

- FACT: To say things are empty is to say they lack **svabhāva**.
- FACT: It is not to say they are absent in every sense.
- FACT: Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, karma and the path are not denied.
- ANALYSIS: Emptiness undercuts metaphysical grasping, not dependent functioning.

5. BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

ANALYSIS: This is a cross-paper theme and should be linked with Proofs for God and Religion without God.

5.1 Core lines of criticism

- FACT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.
- FACT: If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
- FACT: The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- FACT: Dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

5.2 Philosophical force

- ANALYSIS: Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2019 Q5(b), 10 marks:** explain Yogācāra's denial of independently external objects using representations, dreams, seeds and the three natures.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** contrast realist dharmas with Mādhyamika emptiness while preserving their shared causal starting point.
- Use a four-school matrix rather than four disconnected paragraphs.
- Never write "Yogācāra = Advaita" or "Mādhyamika = nihilism".

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Vaibhāṣika: direct external realism.
- Sautrāntika: external cause inferred from representation.
- Yogācāra: *ālaya-vijñāna*, seeds and three natures.
- Mādhyamika: *śūnyatā*, two truths, *catuṣkoṭi*.
- No creator is required because conditioned causation performs the explanatory work.

Progress: 5 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Inter-School Debates and Named Criticism-Reply Chains

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - where rivals apply pressure

NYAYA	-> memory and recognition need an enduring self
MIMAMSA	-> knowledge and universals need stable bearers
ADVAITA	-> liberation is unintelligible without reality/self
CARVAKA	-> no-self is bodily reduction
BUDDHISM	-> causal continuity replaces permanent substance

In simple words: Buddhist process theory solves some problems created by substance, but rivals ask whether a process can remember, act, deserve consequences and attain liberation without an owner.

Memory line: every debate turns on whether causal continuity can perform the work of identity.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

6. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

Debate axis	Buddhist position	Rival / internal contrast
Causation	dependent origination	Nyāya's ārambhavāda; Sāṃkhya's satkāryavāda
Persistence	momentary stream	Nyāya substance with changing qualities
Self	no permanent ātman	Nyāya, Vedānta, Jainism affirm self/jīva
External world	varies by school	Vaibhāṣika realism, Yogācāra idealism, Mādhyamika anti-essentialism
Nirvāṇa	cessation of duḥkha-process	Vedāntic mokṣa as self-realization
God	unnecessary / philosophically problematic	Nyāya theism

6.1 Carvāka's rejection of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman (2024)

- FACT: **Carvāka** denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction.
- FACT: **Buddhism** denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body; it analyses the person into skandhas and preserves karmic continuity without substance.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore both reject an eternal ātman, but for very different reasons and with very different moral-metaphysical consequences.

6.2 Internal Buddhist pūrvapakṣa chain - how the four schools answer one another

Stage	FACT: Siddhānta claimed	ANALYSIS: Becomes pūrvapakṣa for	FACT: Next Buddhist reply
Vaibhāṣika / Sarvāstivāda	FACT: Dharmas are real and, in the Sarvāstivāda sense, have existence across past, present and future.	ANALYSIS: Sautrāntika objects that this weakens momentariness and overpopulates ontology.	FACT: Only the present moment is fully operative; external objects are inferred through representations.
Sautrāntika	FACT: External objects exist but are known inferentially, not directly.	ANALYSIS: Yogācāra objects that an inferred external object is unnecessary because all that is given is cognition.	FACT: Vijñapti-mātra (representation-only): objecthood is inseparable from consciousness-appearance.
Yogācāra	FACT: Consciousness-only explains appearance, karma and continuity through ālaya-vijñāna .	ANALYSIS: Madhyamaka objects that consciousness is being reified as a subtle substance.	FACT: Even consciousness lacks svabhāva ; all dharmas are empty.
Madhyamaka	FACT: Śūnyatā prevents every reification, including reification of emptiness.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita object that this risks nihilism or self-refutation.	FACT: Two truths preserve conventional practice while ultimate analysis denies intrinsic nature.

- ANALYSIS: **Exam payoff**: for “Schools of Buddhism”, do not list four schools mechanically. Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism of dharmas -> presentist representationalism -> idealist consciousness-only -> anti-essentialist emptiness.

7. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES - NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected *santāna* (continuum).

7.1 Nyāya criticism: memory, recognition and moral desert require a permanent self

Objection - Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: **Pratyabhijñā** (recognition) - “this is that same jar” or “I am the same person who saw before” - appears to disclose identity through time.
- FACT: Memory seems to require that the subject who remembers be identical with the subject who experienced.
- FACT: Moral desert seems to require an enduring agent: the doer of an act must be the enjoyer or sufferer of its fruit.

Reply - Buddhist schools

- FACT: **Santāna / santati** (causal series) explains continuity without an identical substance.
- FACT: **Sādrśya** (similarity) explains why recognition mistakes a later similar causal phase for the numerically same object.
- FACT: The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later flame or river-stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.
- FACT: Yogācāra adds **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) and **bīja** (seeds) as the carrier of karmic and mnemonic potential without accepting an ātman.
- ANALYSIS: Nyāya's residual force: a series may explain causal succession, but it is less clear how a series can “own” memories unless some subject owns the series.

7.2 Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Mīmāṃsā criticism: pramāṇa supports self and universals

Objection - Kumārila Bhaṭṭa

- FACT: Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.
- FACT: Kumārila also resists **apoha** by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals, not merely exclusion.
- FACT: A merely negative meaning such as “not-non-cow” seems unable to explain the positive cognition “cow”.

Reply - Buddhist pramāṇa school

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.
- FACT: Apoha explains generality as exclusion grounded in causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgment and action, so a concept is formed without a real universal.
- ANALYSIS: Residual force remains: critics argue that the exclusion must already know what to exclude, making apoha circular.

7.3 Śaṅkara / Advaita criticism: momentariness and emptiness make liberation unintelligible

Objection - Śaṅkara-type Advaita

- FACT: If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.
- FACT: If there is no self, the unity of the knower is unintelligible.
- FACT: If **śūnyatā** is ultimate, the very denial seems to presuppose a self-luminous witnessing consciousness that makes denial possible.

Reply - Buddhist two-truths response

- FACT: Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.
- FACT: At **saṃvṛti-satya** (conventional truth), persons, practice and compassion are valid designations.
- FACT: At **paramārtha-satya** (ultimate truth), neither person nor witness has intrinsic nature.
- ANALYSIS: The Advaitin's residual force is that Buddhist analysis must explain the unity of experience without quietly importing a witness.

7.4 Nyāya / realist criticism: emptiness collapses into nihilism

Objection - Nyāya and common realist charge

- FACT: If all dharma are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.
- FACT: If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.

Reply - Madhyamaka

- FACT: Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.
- FACT: The two truths preserve conventional causation, karma and path-practice while denying intrinsic nature.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna's “empty words” strategy treats philosophical utterance as a therapeutic instrument rather than a final ontology.
- ANALYSIS: Residual force remains in the debate over whether non-implicative negation can avoid becoming a thesis.

7.5 Criticism: karma without self is unjust

Objection - Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta

- FACT: If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.
- FACT: If they are strictly different, punishment or reward would fall on another.

Reply - Buddhist middle position

- FACT: Buddhism rejects both strict identity and strict difference.
- FACT: The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.
- FACT: This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.

- ANALYSIS: The unresolved pressure is whether causal continuity alone is enough for desert, rather than merely for causal explanation.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

Use a dialectic grid: **named opponent** -> **exact target** -> **Buddhist reply** -> **residual pressure**.

For memory, karma and liberation questions, never answer with the word *santāna* alone. Explain causal transmission, similarity, seeds or store-consciousness, then assess whether transmission adequately supplies ownership.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Nyāya: recognition, memory and desert.
- Mīmāṃsā: positive universals and stable cognition.
- Advaita: subject and liberation.
- Buddhist reply: continuity without identity.
- Residual problem: a stream may transmit effects yet still seem to lack an owner.

Progress: 6 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: UPSC Traps, Keyword Control and the Restored Doctrine Dossier

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - four equations to avoid

NO-SELF	!= no conventional person
EMPTINESS	!= nothing exists
MOMENTARINESS	!= causal chaos
NIRVANA	!= immortal ego or simple annihilation

In simple words: most weak answers fail through category errors rather than missing facts. Define what a doctrine denies and what it still preserves.

Memory line: Buddhism removes intrinsic substance while retaining conditioned function.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

- ANALYSIS: **Trap 1:** treating pratītyasamutpāda as a simple linear cosmology. It is primarily a doctrine of dependent suffering and cessation.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 2:** saying momentariness means non-existence. Buddhism says the real conditioned is momentary, not unreal in every sense.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 3:** confusing **pudgala-nairātmya** with **dharma-nairātmya**.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 4:** writing that all Buddhist schools say the same thing about the external world. They do not.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 5:** calling śūnyatā nihilism. Mādhyamika explicitly resists that reading.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 6:** saying Triratna is inconsistent with no-self because "nobody remains to practise." Buddhism admits a conventional person.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 7:** answering karma-under-momentariness by smuggling in a hidden soul. The correct device is **santāna**, not ātman.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 8:** treating catuṣkoṭi as a denial of logic. The Madhyamaka point is non-implicative negation of svabhāva, not casual contradiction.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 9:** writing that Buddhist pramāṇa theory is just Nyāya logic with fewer pramāṇas. It rests on momentary particulars, apoha and no enduring knower.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 10:** confusing Jain non-absolutism with Buddhist no-substance. Jainism preserves jīva and dravya; Buddhism denies self-substance.

9. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda**: dependent origination; this being, that becomes.
- FACT: **Dvādaśa-nidāna**: twelve links of conditioned becoming.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda**: whatever is real is momentary.
- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva**: reality as causal efficiency.
- FACT: **Santāna**: causal stream/continuum.
- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda / anātman**: denial of permanent self.
- FACT: **Skandhas**: rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna.
- FACT: **Pudgala-nairātmya**: no personal self.
- FACT: **Dharma-nairātmya**: no self-nature in dharmas.
- FACT: **Vijñaptimātra**: consciousness-only.
- FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna**: store-consciousness carrying seeds.
- FACT: **Śūnyatā**: emptiness of svabhāva.
- FACT: **Samvṛti / paramārtha**: conventional / ultimate truth.
- FACT: **Avyākata / avyākṛta**: undeclared questions set aside as non-conducive and presuppositionally defective.
- FACT: **Catuṣkoṭi**: four alternatives - is, is-not, both, neither - denied when applied to svabhāva.
- FACT: **Pramāṇa**: valid means of knowledge; Buddhist epistemologists reduce these to perception and inference.
- FACT: **Pratyakṣa / anumāna**: perception of unique particular / inference of conceptual general character.
- FACT: **Svalakṣaṇa / sāmānyalakṣaṇa**: unique causal particular / constructed general character.
- FACT: **Kalpanāpoḍha / abhrānta**: non-conceptual and non-erroneous perception.
- FACT: **Apoha**: exclusion theory of meaning; "cow" functions as "not-non-cow".
- FACT: **Svasaṃvedana**: self-awareness of cognition, attacked by Nyāya and central to Buddhist epistemology.
- FACT: **Pramāṇaphala**: resultant cognition, treated by Dignāga as non-different from the pramāṇa-event.

Quick examinable statements

- ANALYSIS: "Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving."
- ANALYSIS: "Buddhist momentariness is not chaos but ordered succession."
- ANALYSIS: "The person is neither an illusion in the trivial sense nor an ultimate self; it is a valid conventional designation."
- ANALYSIS: "Śūnyatā denies intrinsic being, not dependent functioning."

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:start -->

RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER

Pañcaskandhas, no-self and liberation

- FACT: The person is conventionally designated upon form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; none is permanent, autonomous or fit to be owned as "this is mine, this I am".
- FACT: **Argument**: exhaustive analysis finds only conditioned aggregates; their causal dependence explains continuity without a separate ātman. Liberation is cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation, not the release of a soul-substance.
- ANALYSIS: **Distinction**: no-self denies intrinsic personal substance, not causal continuity or conventional agency.

Dependent origination, momentariness and emptiness

- FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda radicalises conditioned arising: what depends on causes cannot possess unchanging efficacy. Madhyamaka draws the anti-essentialist conclusion that dependently originated things are empty of svabhāva.
- CAUTION: **Objection -> reply**: emptiness seems self-defeating or nihilistic. Nāgārjuna's reply is that emptiness itself is dependent designation and preserves conventional causation rather than abolishing it.

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:end -->

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:start -->

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018-2025 audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership rises to 13 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored years add the Madhyamaka derivation of śūnyatā from dependent origination, no-self with nirvāṇa, kṣaṇikavāda as a derivative of dependent origination and the pañcaskandha account of personhood/liberation.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:end -->

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

Before writing, perform a four-part check:

1. Have I defined the technical term?
2. Have I shown its internal derivation?
3. Have I stated what it does **not** mean?
4. Have I linked it to suffering or liberation?

Use the retained keyword bank and doctrine dossier as the factual checklist for all 13 verified PYQs.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Empty = empty of intrinsic nature.
- No-self = no permanent substance-self.
- Momentary = causally connected momentary events.
- Two truths = conventional operation and ultimate non-intrinsic status.
- Trap: do not call every Buddhist school idealist or nihilist.

Progress: 7 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Buddhist Epistemology and Pragmatic Silence

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - two ways of knowing

PERCEPTION -> unique causal particular, before conceptual construction

INFERENCE -> conceptual and linguistic judgement

Words classify by excluding what the object is not.

In simple words: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept perception and inference as the two fundamental knowledge sources. Perception encounters a unique particular; concepts and words organise experience indirectly.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Svalakṣaṇa</i>	Unique causal particular
<i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i>	Conceptual general character
<i>Apoha</i>	Meaning through exclusion of alternatives
<i>Pramāṇaphala</i>	Result of valid cognition

Memory line: perception presents the particular; inference and language construct usable classifications.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

9A. BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY - THE PRAMĀṆA SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)

ANALYSIS: Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter. It translates **nairātmyavāda** and **kṣaṇikavāda** into a theory of knowledge, language and debate.

9A.1 Two-pramāṇa thesis

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent **pramāṇas** (means of valid knowledge): **pratyakṣa** (perception) and **anumāna** (inference).
- FACT: Other candidates - **upamāna** (comparison), **arthāpatti** (postulation), **anupalabdhi** (non-apprehension) and **śabda** (testimony) - are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.

Argument

1. FACT: A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.
2. FACT: There are exactly two object-types: **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular / self-characterised particular) and **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** (general character / constructed universal-aspect).
3. FACT: Perception grasps the **svalakṣaṇa**.
4. FACT: Inference grasps the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa**.
5. FACT: Therefore there are exactly two pramāṇas.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.
- ANALYSIS: There is no third kind of object beyond the unique causal particular and the constructed general character.

Contrast with Nyāya

Issue	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa school	FACT: Nyāya
Number of pramāṇas	FACT: Two: perception and inference	FACT: Four: perception, inference, comparison, testimony
Testimony	FACT: reducible to inference from reliable signs / speaker-function	FACT: independent pramāṇa
Universals	FACT: conceptual constructions	FACT: real universals inhering in particulars

9A.2 Svalakṣaṇa and sāmānyalakṣaṇa

Feature	FACT: Svalakṣaṇa	FACT: Sāmānyalakṣaṇa
Ontological status	FACT: paramārtha-sat (ultimately real)	FACT: saṃvṛti-sat (conventionally real)
Temporal status	FACT: momentary	ANALYSIS: enduring only as a construct
Cognition	FACT: non-conceptual perception	FACT: conceptual inference / judgment
Language	FACT: ineffable as a unique particular	FACT: expressible and shareable
Causal role	FACT: causally efficient	ANALYSIS: causally inert as a universal construct

Distinction

- FACT: The **svalakṣaṇa** is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.
- FACT: The **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** is shareable, expressible and stable only as a conceptual construction.
- ANALYSIS: This is why Buddhist realism about momentary particulars can coexist with nominalism about universals.

9A.3 Perception as **kalpanāpoḍha** and **abhrānta**

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga defines perception as **kalpanāpoḍha** (free from conceptual construction).
- FACT: Dharmakīrti adds **abhrānta** (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

Why the addition matters

- FACT: Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.
- FACT: Illusions such as a double moon or the circle produced by a whirling firebrand can be vivid while still mistaken.
- ANALYSIS: Dharmakīrti's addition protects Buddhist epistemology from counting every non-conceptual appearance as valid knowledge.

Fourfold division of perception

Type	FACT: Meaning	ANALYSIS: Philosophical point
indriya-pratyakṣa	FACT: sense perception	ANALYSIS: non-conceptual contact with the particular through sense-faculty
mānasa-pratyakṣa	FACT: mental perception	ANALYSIS: immediate mental awareness following sensory presentation
svasaṃvedana	FACT: self-awareness of cognition	ANALYSIS: cognition manifests itself without a second knower
yogi-pratyakṣa	FACT: yogic perception	ANALYSIS: disciplined direct insight into subtle truths relevant to liberation

- ANALYSIS: **Svasaṃvedana** connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

9A.4 Apoha theory of meaning and universals

Statement

- FACT: **Apoha** (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (**jāti**) inhering in particulars.
- FACT: A word functions through **anya-apoha** (exclusion of the other): “cow” means “not-non-cow”.

Argument

1. FACT: Only unique particulars are ultimately real.
2. FACT: Words and concepts are general.
3. FACT: If generality were real, one would need real universals; but universals are not perceived and produce the Nyāya problems of inherence and location.
4. FACT: Therefore generality must be constructed negatively through exclusion.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

Objection - Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara

- FACT: The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.
- FACT: A merely negative content seems unable to explain the positive determinate cognition “cow”.
- FACT: It also seems unable to explain the felt similarity among cows.

Reply - Dharmakīrti's line

- FACT: Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.
- FACT: Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity.
- FACT: Apoha is a conceptual construct erected upon that causal convergence, not upon a prior grasp of a real universal.

- ANALYSIS: The circularity objection retains residual force; many critics hold that the Buddhist reply does not fully explain positive determination.

9A.5 Arthakriyākāritva as the criterion of the real

Statement

- FACT: **Sat = arthakriyā-samartha**: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.
- FACT: This criterion ranks the **svalakṣaṇa** as ultimately real and the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** as conventional.

Argument connecting epistemology to kṣaṇikavāda

1. FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious.
2. FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either successively or simultaneously.
3. FACT: A permanent entity can do neither coherently: if it produces everything at once, nothing remains for later moments; if it produces successively, it changes; if it needs auxiliary conditions, the decisive efficacy lies in the changing conditions.
4. FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary - **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.

Exam payoff

- ANALYSIS: This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

9A.6 Pramāṇa and pramāṇaphala

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that **pramāṇa** (instrument of knowledge) and **pramāṇaphala** (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.
- FACT: The resultant cognition - the determination of the object and the self-awareness of cognition - is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa.

Argument

- FACT: On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.
- FACT: The analysis into **karaṇa** (instrument) and **phala** (result) is a conceptual overlay on one momentary cognitive event.
- ANALYSIS: This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by **anātman** and **kṣaṇikavāda**, not by free-standing formal logic.

Contrast with Nyāya

Factor	FACT: Nyāya	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa school
pramātṛ (knower)	FACT: real enduring subject	ANALYSIS: constructed stream, not ultimate self
pramāṇa (instrument)	FACT: distinct means	FACT: non-different from cognition as event
prameya (object)	FACT: independently knowable object	FACT: ultimately svalakṣaṇa; conventionally constructed object
pramiti / pramāṇaphala (result)	FACT: distinct resultant knowledge	FACT: not ultimately separate from pramāṇa

9B. AVYĀKATA / AVYĀKRṬA QUESTIONS - PRAGMATIC SILENCE

9B.1 The undeclared questions

- FACT: **Avyākata / avyākṛta** (undeclared / unanswered) questions are questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format.
- FACT: They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the **jīva** (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the **Tathāgata** exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

AVYĀKṚTA CLUSTER
 World: eternal? not eternal? finite? infinite?
 Self/body: jīva same as body? different from body?
 Tathāgata after death: exists? does not exist? both? neither?

9B.2 Why the Buddha declined

Statement

- FACT: The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

Argument

1. FACT: The questions are **na arthasaṃhita** (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation).
2. FACT: The arrow parable in the **Cūḷamālukya** teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment.
3. FACT: The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated.
4. ANALYSIS: The structure resembles the loaded question "Have you stopped beating your wife?"; any direct answer concedes the presupposition.
5. FACT: Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

9B.3 Fire-going-out simile

- FACT: For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.
- ANALYSIS: The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

9B.4 Three readings of the silence

Reading	Claim	Strength	Limit
CAUTION: Agnostic	CAUTION: The Buddha did not know, or the matter is unknowable.	ANALYSIS: Explains non-answering simply.	ANALYSIS: Fits poorly with the strong positive diagnosis of suffering and cessation.
FACT: Pragmatic-therapeutic	FACT: The questions are useless for liberation.	FACT: Best fits the arrow parable's stated reason.	ANALYSIS: May understate the logical problem in the questions.
ANALYSIS: Logical-semantic	ANALYSIS: The questions are malformed because their presupposition of substantial self/world fails.	ANALYSIS: Best fits anātman and dependent origination.	CAUTION: Not always explicitly formulated as a formal semantic theory in early sources.

- CAUTION: The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.
- ANALYSIS: For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective.

9B.5 Objection and reply

Objection - realist / metaphysical critic

- FACT: Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

Reply - Buddhist middle way

- FACT: The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, path and cessation.
- FACT: The middle way avoids both **śāśvatavāda** (eternalism) and **ucchedavāda** (annihilationism).
- FACT: Answering the avyākṛta questions in any of the four corners would concede the grammar of one of those extremes.

- ANALYSIS: Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- For *pramāṇa* questions, compare Buddhist two-*pramāṇa* theory with Nyāya's fourfold scheme.
- Define *kalpanāpoḍha* and explain why later Buddhists add non-erroneousness.
- In *apoha*, present the economy gained and the positive-content objection.
- Use pragmatic silence only where relevant; do not turn it into a blanket ban on philosophy.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Two *pramāṇas*: perception and inference.
- Perception is non-conceptual and non-erroneous.
- Particulars are ultimately causally real; universals are conceptual.
- *Apoha*: exclusion of the other.
- *Avyākata*: questions left undeclared because they do not conduce to liberation.

Progress: 8 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Comparative Synthesis, PYQ Routing and Answer Architecture

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - the complete Buddhist answer spine

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION
|
IMPERMANENCE / MOMENTARINESS
|
NO PERMANENT SELF
|
CAUSAL CONTINUITY OF KARMA
|
CESSATION OF SUFFERING

In simple words: answer Buddhism as a connected process philosophy. Begin with conditions, derive change and no-self, explain continuity, and end with liberation.

Marks	Minimum structure
10	Define -> derive -> distinction -> significance
15	Doctrine -> example -> objection/reply -> verdict
20	Full causal chain -> school comparison -> dialectic -> assessment

Memory line: no substance is required if conditioned continuity can explain arising, responsibility and cessation.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

9C. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

Doctrine	Presupposition	What collapses if denied
FACT: Pratītyasamutpāda	ANALYSIS: Explanation must proceed through conditions rather than a static first substance.	ANALYSIS: The Four Noble Truths lose their causal grammar; suffering becomes fate or mystery.
FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda	ANALYSIS: Whatever is conditioned and causally efficient cannot remain numerically permanent.	ANALYSIS: Buddhist critique of substance weakens; Nyāya-style endurance becomes possible.
FACT: Nairātmyavāda	ANALYSIS: Exhaustive analysis of experience finds aggregates and processes, not an owner behind them.	ANALYSIS: Karma and nirvāṇa must be reinterpreted through an ātman, which Buddhism refuses.
FACT: Arthakriyākāritva	ANALYSIS: Reality is measured by effect-producing capacity, not by inert self-identity.	ANALYSIS: Momentariness loses its strongest logical bridge from epistemology to ontology.
FACT: Apoha	ANALYSIS: Generality can be explained by exclusion and causal convergence without real universals.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya-Mīmāṃsā universals regain explanatory force.
FACT: Two truths	ANALYSIS: Conventional functioning and ultimate analysis answer different questions.	ANALYSIS: Madhyamaka appears either nihilist or secretly realist.
FACT: Śūnyatā	ANALYSIS: Whatever is dependently arisen lacks svabhāva.	ANALYSIS: Dependent origination remains a mere causal theory and does not become anti-essentialist.
FACT: Nirvāṇa	ANALYSIS: Bondage is a conditioned process; cessation is possible without a liberated soul-substance.	ANALYSIS: No-self and liberation appear inconsistent.

9D. PŪRVAPAKṢA-SIDDHĀNTA LEDGER

Objector (named)	Objection	Buddhist reply (school / thinker)	Residual force ANALYSIS:
FACT: Nyāya - Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana	FACT: Recognition, memory and moral desert require an enduring self.	FACT: Sautrāntika/Yogācāra: santāna , sādrśya , flame/river analogies; Yogācāra adds ālaya-vijñāna and bīja .	ANALYSIS: A series may not "own" memories unless something owns the series.
FACT: Nyāya realist	FACT: A permanent substance can act when auxiliaries are present.	FACT: Dharmakīrti line: sahakāri-anapekṣā / kramayaugapadya dilemma; changing conditions do the real work.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's substance-quality model remains intuitively powerful.
FACT: Kumārila Bhaṭṭa	FACT: Self is required for duty, memory and pramāṇa; universals are required for word-meaning.	FACT: Dignāga/Dharmakīrti: momentary cognitions plus apoha explain self and generality conventionally.	ANALYSIS: Apoha's positive-determination problem persists.
FACT: Uddyotakara	FACT: Apoha is circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know cow.	FACT: Dharmakīrti: exclusion is grounded in causal convergence and successful activity, not a prior universal.	ANALYSIS: The circularity charge is not fully dissolved for many critics.
FACT: Śaṃkara / Advaita	FACT: Momentariness makes bondage/liberation and unity of knower unintelligible; śūnyatā presupposes witnessing consciousness.	FACT: Madhyamaka/Yogācāra replies through two truths and self-revealing cognition without ātman.	ANALYSIS: Unity of experience remains the strongest Advaitic pressure point.
FACT: Nyāya / modern realist	FACT: Catuṣkoṭi denial is self-contradictory or says nothing.	FACT: Nāgārjuna: non-implicative negation; empty words cure empty reification; no independent thesis.	ANALYSIS: Prāsaṅgika vs Svātantrika dispute shows internal unease.
FACT: Puggalavāda / Vātsīputrīya foil	FACT: A person neither identical with nor different from skandhas is needed for continuity.	FACT: Mainstream Buddhism: this risks reintroducing a disguised self; continuity is conventional designation on aggregates.	ANALYSIS: The pressure to preserve agency explains why the foil arose.
FACT: Cārvāka materialist	FACT: Reject self beyond body and deny post-mortem continuity.	FACT: Buddhism rejects permanent self but preserves karmic causal continuity beyond gross-body reduction.	ANALYSIS: Requires accepting causal continuity not directly reducible to perception.

9E. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING

School	Pramāṇas	Ontology of self	Permanence / change	Causation	Universals	Scripture	Liberation
FACT: Buddhism	FACT: Dignāga -Dharmakīrti: two, perception and inference	FACT: no permanent ātman; person is aggregate / stream	FACT: conditioned reals are momentary	FACT: dependent origination	FACT: apoha; no real jāti	FACT: Buddha-word valued, but not Vedic infallibility	FACT: cessation of ignorance, craving and duḥkha-process
FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	FACT: usually four in classical Nyāya	FACT: enduring self-substance	FACT: substances endure through changing qualities	FACT: ārambhavāda-style production and theistic order in later Nyāya	FACT: real universals	FACT: testimony as pramāṇa, Veda accepted	FACT: true knowledge of self and categories, cessation of suffering
FACT: Sāṃkhya-Yoga	FACT: perception, inference and reliable testimony	FACT: many puruṣas	FACT: puruṣa permanent; prakṛti transforms	FACT: satkāryavāda / parināma	ANALYSIS: less central than tattva structure	FACT: scripture accepted with reasoning	FACT: kaivalya, isolation of puruṣa from prakṛti
FACT: Jainism	FACT: multiple pramāṇa/naya approaches	FACT: real jīva, intrinsically conscious	FACT: substance persists with changing modes	FACT: anekāntavāda and parināmic change	FACT: real common features within many-sided realism	FACT: Jaina āgama authority	FACT: release of jīva from karmic matter
FACT: Mīmāṃsā	FACT: expands pramāṇas; Kumārila accepts several including arthāpatti and anupalabdhi	FACT: enduring self as agent/enjoyer	FACT: enduring subject and real ritual order	FACT: ritual efficacy and apūrva	FACT: real universals	FACT: Veda intrinsically authoritative	FACT: often framed through dharma and cessation of obstacles, varies by sub-school
FACT: Cārvāka	FACT: perception alone	FACT: self identified with body / consciousness as bodily product	FACT: material elements persist; no rebirth-continuity	FACT: material causation only	ANALYSIS: rejects metaphysical universals beyond perception	FACT: rejects Veda	FACT: no mokṣa beyond worldly well-being
FACT: Advaita Vedānta	FACT: six in developed Advaita	FACT: ātman = Brahman, self-luminous	FACT: Brahman permanent; world ultimately mithyā	FACT: vivarta / appearance	ANALYSIS: empirical universals within māyā	FACT: Upaniṣadic revelation central	FACT: knowledge of Brahman

9E.1 Buddhism vs Jainism - high-yield distinction

- FACT: Both are non-Vedic śramaṇa traditions and both reject a creator God as necessary for liberation.
- FACT: Jainism affirms **anekāntavāda** (many-sidedness): a substance can be permanent in substance and changing in modes.
- FACT: Buddhism denies substance: what looks like persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying dravya.
- FACT: The Jaina **jīva** is real and omniscient by nature when freed from karmic obstruction; the Buddhist self is a construct designated on skandhas.
- ANALYSIS: Trap to avoid: do not say both deny the soul. Buddhism denies ātman; Jainism strongly affirms jīva.

9E.2 Buddhism vs Advaita - avoid the “crypto-Advaita” trap

- FACT: Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.
- FACT: Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous **Brahman / ātman**.

- FACT: Madhyamaka **śūnyatā** is absence of **svabhāva**, not a hidden substrate.
- FACT: Advaita sublates world into Brahman; Madhyamaka refuses to replace empty phenomena with a metaphysical ground.
- ANALYSIS: Trap to refute: "Buddhist emptiness is just Advaita Brahman under another name." The Buddhist case is anti-substantialist; Advaita is absolute-substantialist.

9F. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

Western comparison	Point of contact	Disanalogy
FACT: Hume's bundle theory vs anātman	FACT: Both deny a substantial self on broadly empiricist grounds.	ANALYSIS: Hume has no karmic continuity, no nirvāṇa-soteriology and treats self as imagination's fiction; Buddhism has a morally weighted causal series.
FACT: Heraclitus' flux vs kṣaṇikavāda	FACT: Both stress universal change.	ANALYSIS: Heraclitus retains logos as ordering principle; Buddhist momentariness is tied to dependent origination and causal efficacy.
FACT: Whitehead's process thought vs momentary dharmas	FACT: Both treat reality as event/process rather than inert substance.	ANALYSIS: Whitehead's metaphysical scheme is not the Buddhist no-self path and has no apoha or nirvāṇa framework.
FACT: Nāgārjuna's catuṣkoṭi vs Kant's antinomies	FACT: Both show reason generating opposed metaphysical conclusions.	ANALYSIS: Kant preserves the phenomenal object and limits categories; Nāgārjuna targets svabhāva itself through emptiness.
FACT: Wittgenstein's therapeutic philosophy vs Buddha's silence	FACT: Both dissolve misleading questions rather than answer them on their own terms.	ANALYSIS: The Buddha's therapy is soteriological and rooted in duḥkha, karma and liberation.
FACT: Ockham's nominalism vs apoha	FACT: Both deny real universals.	ANALYSIS: Apoha's negative-exclusion mechanism and karmic-epistemic background have no exact Ockhamite counterpart; Ockham retains enduring individuals.

- **ANALYSIS: Rubric:** Western parallels are illustrative only; they must never replace the Indian argument and belong in at most one or two lines after the Buddhist case is complete.

9G. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Buddhism answer	Closing verdict
Discuss	FACT: balanced exposition of doctrine and significance	ANALYSIS: define -> explain argument -> add school nuance -> conclude	ANALYSIS: "Thus the doctrine is central because..."
Examine	FACT: internal logic and assumptions	ANALYSIS: state thesis -> reconstruct reasoning -> expose presupposition	ANALYSIS: "It stands if its presupposition about ... is accepted."
Critically examine	FACT: doctrine plus objections/replies	ANALYSIS: doctrine -> named objection -> Buddhist reply -> residual force	ANALYSIS: "Strong as soteriology, debated as metaphysics."
Analyse	FACT: break doctrine into components	ANALYSIS: divide into causation, self, moment, liberation, epistemology	ANALYSIS: "The components converge on anti-substantialism."
Evaluate	FACT: final judgment on adequacy	ANALYSIS: strengths -> weaknesses -> contested point -> verdict	ANALYSIS: "Adequate for ..., weaker against ..."
Compare	FACT: similarity and difference across schools	ANALYSIS: use a table; then add one decisive contrast	ANALYSIS: "Similarity is formal; difference is doctrinal."
Distinguish	FACT: precise separation of close terms	ANALYSIS: two-column definitions, criteria and example	ANALYSIS: "Confusing them causes the standard UPSC trap."
Elucidate	FACT: clarify with examples	ANALYSIS: statement -> example -> doctrinal consequence	ANALYSIS: "The example shows the doctrine's exact sense."
Comment	FACT: interpret a quotation / claim	ANALYSIS: unpack claim -> support -> qualify -> conclude	ANALYSIS: "The claim is acceptable if read as ... not as ..."
Bring out	FACT: make an implicit relation explicit	ANALYSIS: show link, e.g. <i>pratītyasamutpāda</i> -> <i>kṣaṇikavāda</i> -> <i>nairātmya</i>	ANALYSIS: "The relation is logical, not merely historical."
Do you agree?	FACT: reasoned position	ANALYSIS: partial agreement -> objection -> defended verdict	ANALYSIS: "I agree in the conventional/ultimate sense specified above."

9H. GRADED VERDICT ON BUDDHISM

9H.1 What is strong

- FACT: Buddhism gives a powerful process-based account of suffering, causation and liberation through **pratītyasamutpāda**.
- FACT: It avoids both eternalism and annihilationism by using causal continuity without an eternal self.
- FACT: *Kṣaṇikavāda* is supported by a sharp causal-efficacy argument, especially in Dharmakīrti's *pramāṇa* framework.
- FACT: Madhyamaka's two truths allow it to deny intrinsic nature without abolishing ordinary practice.

9H.2 What is weak

- ANALYSIS: The denial of a persisting subject makes memory, recognition and moral desert philosophically difficult.
- ANALYSIS: Apoha explains universals economically but struggles to account for positive determinate cognition.
- ANALYSIS: *Catuṣkoṭi* and "no thesis" replies can look self-referentially unstable unless the non-implicative-negation nuance is clearly stated.

9H.3 What is genuinely contested

- CAUTION: Whether **svasaṃvedana** proves self-awareness or merely reifies cognition is debated between Buddhist epistemologists and Nyāya.
- CAUTION: Whether Madhyamaka's empty statements avoid self-refutation is debated both internally and by opponents.

- CAUTION: Whether a causal series is sufficient for moral responsibility without an owner remains the core cross-school dispute.

9H.4 Ready one-line verdicts

- ANALYSIS: **10 marks:** Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process: this makes suffering removable, but raises the problem of continuity without self.
- ANALYSIS: **15 marks:** Its doctrines of dependent origination, momentariness and no-self form a coherent anti-substantialist system, though Nyāya and Vedānta press hard on memory, agency and liberation.
- ANALYSIS: **20 marks:** Buddhism is strongest as a therapeutic and causal philosophy of liberation; its deepest unresolved issue is whether causal continuity and two truths can fully replace the metaphysical work done by self, substance and universals in rival systems.

10. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 13 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.
2018	Q6(b)	15 marks	Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.
2019	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.
2019	Q7(c)	15 marks	What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?
2020	Q6(a)	20 marks	How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.
2020	Q7(b)	15 marks	How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?
2021	Q5(d)	10 marks	Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.
2021	Q7(b)	15 marks	If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.
2022	Q6(a)	20 marks	How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.
2022	Q7(b)	15 marks	Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).
2023	Q8(a)	20 marks	"Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.
2024	Q6(b)	15 marks	How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda? Answer with arguments.
2025	Q8(c)	15 marks	Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

11. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Final verdict: Buddhist philosophy replaces substantial identity with dependent continuity, but its success depends on explaining how causal efficacy, knowledge and liberation remain coherent without a permanent self or intrinsic essence.

11.1 For a 10-marker

Define the doctrine in one line.

State the core argument in 3-4 crisp steps.

Add one distinction (e.g. pudgala- vs dharma-nairātmya; realism vs emptiness).

Close with one line of significance.

11.2 For a 15-marker

Intro: locate the issue in Buddhist soteriology.

Body A: doctrine stated precisely.

Body B: argument with one example.

Body C: objection and Buddhist reply.

Conclusion: show why the doctrine matters for duḥkha / nirvāṇa.

11.3 For a 20-marker

Frame: connect the question to the Four Noble Truths.

Exposition: full doctrine with technical vocabulary.

Analysis: derive the linked Buddhist claim (e.g. momentariness from dependent origination).

Debate: contrast two schools or answer a major objection.

Verdict: give a balanced philosophical assessment.

12. LINK-OUTS

- Nyaya-Vaisesika.md - contrast on self, causation, pramāṇa and God.
- Carvaka.md - contrast on self and rejection of transcendence.
- Jainism.md - compare continuity-through-change with Buddhist momentariness.
- ../_themes/Causation-across-schools.md - pratītyasamutpāda vs satkāryavāda vs ārambhavāda.
- ../_themes/Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md - anātman vs ātman accounts.
- ../_PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md - year-wise Indian Philosophy routing.
- .././paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md - cross-paper God debate.
- .././paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Religion-without-God.md - Buddhism as a non-theistic religion.
- .././paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md - rebirth without immortal soul.

SOURCES

- *Majjhima Nikāya* and related early Buddhist formulations of dependent origination, used in substance where directly phrased.
- Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, especially the standard identification in substance of dependent origination and emptiness.
- Chatterjee & Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. I and II, where relevant to Buddhist schools.
- Standard expositions of *Milinda-pañha* for the chariot analogy, paraphrased where exact wording is uncertain.
- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, standard pramāṇa-school doctrines of perception, inference, apoha and pramāṇaphala, paraphrased without verse-number claims.
- FACT: Early Buddhist discussions of the avyākata / avyākṛta questions and the Cūḷamālukya arrow parable, used in substance without invented citation numbering.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna, *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, for the no-thesis / self-referential defence, used in substance without verse-number claims.

CURRENT LINKAGE - BUDDHIST HERITAGE AS CULTURAL DIPLOMACY

FACT: Official fact: The High Commission of India in Colombo reported that India sent the Devnimori Buddha relics from Gujarat to the Gangaramaya Temple, Colombo, for public exposition from **4 to 10 February 2026**. The official release described the initiative as cultural and spiritual engagement with Sri Lanka through shared Buddhist heritage.

ANALYSIS: Philosophy Optional use: This event does not prove any Buddhist doctrine. Use it only as a contemporary introduction or conclusion showing how a philosophical-religious tradition also functions as a civilizational language in diplomacy. Doctrinal answers must remain grounded in *pratityasamutpada*, momentariness, no-self, the two truths, compassion, and the relevant school.

Source trail used for this package

- FACT: Repository owner: `paper-1/indian/Buddhism.md`.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 149-194: dependent origination, transience, no-self, and the four schools.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 67-81: early Buddhism, twelve links, momentariness, realist schools, and nirvana.
- FACT: Official High Commission of India, Colombo release on the Devnimori relic exposition, rechecked 18 August 2026.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

The complete corpus contains **13 primary-owned questions from 2018-2025**:

- Dependent origination and emptiness: 2018.
- Yogācāra external-world critique: 2019.
- Momentariness derivation: 2019 and 2020.
- No-self, aggregates and *nirvāṇa*: 2018, 2020, 2021 and 2025.
- Memory and karma under momentariness: 2021 and 2022.
- Triratna and no-self: 2022.
- Soteriology through dependent origination: 2023.
- Realism versus emptiness: 2024.

The retained routing table, directive decoder and marks-wise frameworks below should be used before attempting the full solved practice.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall - final master matrix

Prompt	Recall spine
Causation	conditioned arising and cessation
Reality	causal efficacy; momentary particulars
Person	five aggregates and causal designation
Continuity	<i>santāna</i> , seeds and store-consciousness
Schools	direct realism -> inferred realism -> cognition-only -> emptiness
Language	<i>apoha</i>
Liberation	cessation of the causes of suffering
Verdict	process without substance; continuity with an ownership burden

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

Master verdict: Buddhism is a family of anti-substantialist, causally ordered and soteriological systems; its schools range from realism through consciousness-only analysis to radical emptiness.

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Master verdict: Buddhism is a family of anti-substantialist, causally ordered and soteriological systems; its schools range from realism through consciousness-only analysis to radical emptiness.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It is the key to the arising of *duḥkha* and therefore the key to its cessation.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

ANALYSIS: Exam key: In Buddhism, the three syllabus terms are not separate islands.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: *pratītyasamutpāda* (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which formulation best expresses the general principle of *Pratītyasamutpāda*?

A. Conditioned phenomena arise and cease with their supporting conditions. B. Every effect already exists materially in its cause. C. An eternal self coordinates otherwise disconnected events. D. A creator initiates the first member of every causal series.

Answer: A. Conditioned phenomena arise and cease with their supporting conditions.

Explanation: The formula “this being, that arises; with the cessation of this, that ceases” states conditionality. It avoids eternalism because no conditioned entity is immutable, and avoids annihilationism because events arise in ordered dependence rather than from nothing.

2. In the Four Noble Truths, *Pratītyasamutpāda* most directly explains the relation between:

A. right speech and right livelihood. B. the origin of *duḥkha* and its possible cessation. C. perception and inference. D. Buddha and Saṅgha.

Answer: B. The origin of *duḥkha* and its possible cessation.

Explanation: Dependent origination supplies the causal grammar of the second and third truths: suffering arises because relevant conditions operate, and it ceases when those conditions—especially ignorance, craving and clinging—are removed.

3. Which sequence correctly presents the first four *nidānas*?

A. *vijñāna* -> *avidyā* -> *nāma-rūpa* -> *saṃskāra* B. *avidyā* -> *vijñāna* -> *saṃskāra* -> *nāma-rūpa* C. *avidyā* -> *saṃskāra* -> *vijñāna* -> *nāma-rūpa* D. *saṃskāra* -> *avidyā* -> *nāma-rūpa* -> *vijñāna*

Answer: C. *Avidyā* -> *saṃskāra* -> *vijñāna* -> *nāma-rūpa*.

Explanation: Ignorance conditions formations, formations condition consciousness, and consciousness conditions name-and-form. Confusing *saṃskāra* and *vijñāna* is a frequent factual trap.

4. Which sequence correctly completes the twelve-link chain after *vedanā*?

A. *upādāna* -> *trṣṇā* -> *jāti* -> *bhava* -> *jarā-maraṇa* B. *trṣṇā* -> *bhava* -> *upādāna* -> *jāti* -> *jarā-maraṇa* C. *bhava* -> *trṣṇā* -> *upādāna* -> *jarā-maraṇa* -> *jāti* D. *trṣṇā* -> *upādāna* -> *bhava* -> *jāti* -> *jarā-maraṇa*

Answer: D. *Trṣṇā* -> *upādāna* -> *bhava* -> *jāti* -> *jarā-maraṇa*.

Explanation: Feeling conditions craving, craving clinging, clinging becoming, becoming birth, and birth ageing-and-death. The practical intervention point is crucial: feeling need not automatically harden into craving.

5. Why does dependent origination not imply fatalism?

A. Because altering conditions can interrupt the production of suffering. B. Because karmic effects occur without causes. C. Because an unconditioned self can leave the causal order. D. Because every link must unfold identically in every person.

Answer: A. Because altering conditions can interrupt the production of suffering.

Explanation: Conditionality makes practice meaningful. Ethics, mindfulness and insight change the causal environment; therefore the chain is explanatory and soteriological, not a fixed destiny.

6. The most defensible route from dependent origination to Kṣaṇikavāda is:

A. dependence immediately proves that every event lasts exactly one measurable instant. B. conditional impermanence plus the argument from causal efficacy supports moment-specific existence. C. only what is permanent can produce a novel effect. D. causal series require an unchanging substratum.

Answer: B. Conditional impermanence plus the argument from causal efficacy supports moment-specific existence.

Explanation: Pratītyasamutpāda directly establishes conditioned impermanence. Strict momentariness requires the added *arthakriyā* argument that real causal operation belongs to a determinate, changing phase.

7. Arthakriyākāritva means:

A. membership in a real universal. B. correspondence between a word and an eternal meaning. C. capacity to perform an effective causal function. D. recognition by an enduring subject.

Answer: C. Capacity to perform an effective causal function.

Explanation: Dignāga-Dharmakīrti traditions connect reality with causal efficacy. Since unique particulars alone produce effects, the criterion also supports their momentariness.

8. In the Buddhist simultaneity/succession dilemma, a wholly permanent cause is problematic because:

A. it must be imperceptible. B. it cannot possess qualities. C. it would become a universal. D. unchanged complete power gives no reason for delayed or successive production.

Answer: D. Unchanged complete power gives no reason for delayed or successive production.

Explanation: If the power is complete, the effect should occur immediately or continuously. If the cause gains a new operative power later, it has changed and is not wholly permanent.

9. What is the Buddhist response when Nyāya says a permanent cause waits for sahakārin auxiliary conditions?

A. If auxiliaries alter causal capacity, the operative complex is not wholly unchanged; if not, delay remains unexplained. B. Auxiliary conditions are always illusions. C. Every cause and effect is simultaneous. D. Permanent substances exist but cannot be known.

Answer: A. If auxiliaries alter causal capacity, the operative complex is not wholly unchanged; if not, delay remains unexplained.

Explanation: The reply targets explanatory work. Either the auxiliary contributes a difference, undermining strict permanence of the operative cause, or it contributes none, leaving delayed action mysterious.

10. Santāna is best understood as:

A. a subtle permanent soul concealed beneath momentary states. B. a causally connected continuum of numerically distinct moments. C. an eternal universal instantiated in persons. D. the final destruction of all causal relations.

Answer: B. A causally connected continuum of numerically distinct moments.

Explanation: *Santāna* preserves transmission, regularity and practical identity without numerical sameness. No-self denies a substance-bearer, not causal continuity.

11. Which statement best captures the Buddhist account of memory under momentariness?

A. Memory is impossible and only appears to occur. B. One permanent cognition survives from experience to recollection. C. An experience conditions a disposition that is transmitted and later produces recollection. D. Memory is supplied by a creator to each mental stream.

Answer: C. An experience conditions a disposition that is transmitted and later produces recollection.

Explanation: Sautrāntika uses traces or seeds, while Yogācāra systematizes their preservation through *ālaya-vijñāna*. The account explains causal transmission without an enduring experiencer.

12. Nyāya's strongest pressure on the Buddhist memory theory is that:

A. memory contains no past-directed content. B. causal continuity is impossible between moments. C. all recognition is inference from universals. D. "I experienced this" seems to require one subject owning both experience and recollection.

Answer: D. "I experienced this" seems to require one subject owning both experience and recollection.

Explanation: The Buddhist stream theory explains why information reappears, but Nyāya asks whether it explains first-person appropriation. The Buddhist reply treats ownership as constructed within an integrated causal continuum.

13. Which set contains only the five skandhas?

A. *rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna* B. *rūpa, ātman, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna* C. *dravya, guṇa, karma, sāmānya, viśeṣa* D. *buddhi, ahaṃkāra, manas, tanmātra, puruṣa*

Answer: A. Rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna.

Explanation: These are form, feeling, recognition, formations and consciousness. Buddhism finds no permanent self as one aggregate, their total, or their independent owner.

14. The Milinda-pañha chariot analogy primarily establishes that:

A. persons do not exist even conventionally. B. "person" is a dependent designation upon an organized aggregate-stream. C. the body alone is the self. D. a hidden substance unifies the parts.

Answer: B. "Person" is a dependent designation upon an organized aggregate-stream.

Explanation: The analogy rejects a separately findable substantial person while preserving conventional reference and practical agency. It is not eliminative nihilism.

15. How does dharma-nairātmya extend pudgala-nairātmya?

A. It restores a permanent self at the level of consciousness. B. It denies conventional persons but accepts eternal dharmas. C. It denies intrinsic self-nature not only in persons but also in constituent phenomena. D. It limits no-self to bodily form.

Answer: C. It denies intrinsic self-nature not only in persons but also in constituent phenomena.

Explanation: Personal no-self is shared broadly; Mahāyāna emphatically extends non-selfhood to dharmas. This prevents momentary elements from becoming replacement substances.

16. Which statement best reconciles Nirvāṇa with no-self?

A. Nirvāṇa is the immortality of a purified ego. B. An ātman temporarily disappears and later returns. C. Nirvāṇa destroys an actually existing eternal soul. D. Nirvāṇa is cessation of the causes of suffering within a causal stream, without an eternal owner.

Answer: D. Nirvāṇa is cessation of the causes of suffering within a causal stream, without an eternal owner.

Explanation: The practitioner and liberated continuum are causally related without being one immutable substance. No-self removes the appropriation that feeds craving rather than abolishing the path.

17. Vaibhāṣika is most accurately described as:

A. direct realism about external, momentary dharmas. B. representational realism in which objects are only inferred. C. cognition-only idealism. D. universal emptiness of all dharmas.

Answer: A. Direct realism about external, momentary dharmas.

Explanation: Vaibhāṣika treats external dharmas as real and directly perceived. It differs from Sautrāntika about epistemic access and from Mādhyamaka about ultimate status.

18. Sautrāntika differs from Vaibhāṣika chiefly because it holds that:

A. no external objects exist. B. external objects are inferred from cognition's representations rather than directly perceived. C. only universals are causally efficient. D. consciousness is an eternal substance.

Answer: B. External objects are inferred from cognition's representations rather than directly perceived.

Explanation: Sautrāntika remains realist but is representational or inferential in epistemology. The mental form is directly known; an external cause is inferred.

19. Which statement about Yogācāra is most accurate?

A. A private ego freely imagines whatever world it wants. B. Yogācāra is identical to Advaita because both use consciousness vocabulary. C. *Vijñaptimātratā* denies independently established external objects while retaining a conditioned and ordered cognitive flow. D. Yogācāra denies karma and intersubjective regularity.

Answer: C. Vijñaptimātratā denies independently established external objects while retaining a conditioned and ordered cognitive flow.

Explanation: Yogācāra is not whimsical subjective idealism. Karmic seeds and shared conditioning explain structured experience, while the subject-object split is analysed as constructed.

20. What is the main function of ālaya-vijñāna?

A. To serve as an eternal ātman. B. To create matter ex nihilo. C. To guarantee knowledge of external substances. D. To carry karmic and cognitive seeds through a changing stream.

Answer: D. To carry karmic and cognitive seeds through a changing stream.

Explanation: Store-consciousness explains continuity, memory and coordinated experience. Yogācāra insists that it too is conditioned and transformable, so treating it as a permanent self is a factual error.

21. In the tri-svabhāva, parikalpita refers to:

A. the imagined construction of independent subject-object duality. B. the dependently arisen cognitive flow. C. the perfected realization of non-duality. D. an eternal material substratum.

Answer: A. The imagined construction of independent subject-object duality.

Explanation: *Paratantra* is the dependent flow; *pariṇippanna* is realization of the absence of the imagined duality. The three are analytical aspects, not three separate substances.

22. In the tri-svabhāva, paratantra is:

A. sheer non-being. B. the dependently arisen flow conditioned by causes and seeds. C. permanent pure consciousness. D. the external object as directly perceived.

Answer: B. The dependently arisen flow conditioned by causes and seeds.

Explanation: Yogācāra does not deny the causal process of cognition. It denies the independently real duality projected upon that dependent flow.

23. In the tri-svabhāva, pariṇippanna is:

A. the persistence of subject-object duality at the ultimate level. B. the independent existence of store-consciousness. C. perfected realization of the dependent flow's freedom from imagined duality. D. the inference from a representation to matter.

Answer: C. Perfected realization of the dependent flow's freedom from imagined duality.

Explanation: The perfected nature is not another substance behind experience. It is the dependent nature correctly known as lacking the projected dual structure.

24. Which statement best expresses Mādhyamaka Śūnyatā?

A. Nothing exists or functions at any level. B. Only consciousness possesses ultimate being. C. Empty things cannot enter causal relations. D. Phenomena lack intrinsic *svabhāva* while functioning conventionally through dependence.

Answer: D. Phenomena lack intrinsic svabhāva while functioning conventionally through dependence.

Explanation: Emptiness is anti-essentialism, not nothingness. Dependent functioning and emptiness are mutually implicative: fixed essences would make change and causal interaction impossible.

25. Why does Mādhyamaka say that dependent origination implies emptiness?

A. What depends on causes and designation cannot possess independent own-nature. B. Every effect must pre-exist in a permanent cause. C. Dependence proves that only matter is real. D. Causal relations are logically impossible.

Answer: A. What depends on causes and designation cannot possess independent own-nature.

Explanation: *Svabhāva* would mean self-establishment. Dependence is therefore incompatible with intrinsic essence, though fully compatible with conventional existence.

26. The two truths are:

A. perception and inference. B. conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*) and ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*). C. mind and matter. D. permanence and annihilation.

Answer: B. Conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*) and ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*).

Explanation: Conventionally, language, ethics and causation work; ultimately, no entity has independent *svabhāva*. The distinction prevents both reification and nihilism.

27. “Emptiness of emptiness” chiefly prevents:

A. ethical action. B. conventional discourse. C. reification of Śūnyatā into a new Absolute. D. analysis of causal conditions.

Answer: C. Reification of Śūnyatā into a new Absolute.

Explanation: Emptiness is itself dependently designated and has no own-nature. It is a therapeutic critique of essence, not an ultimate substance.

28. How can realist Buddhism and Mādhyamaka draw opposed conclusions from Pratīyasamutpāda?

A. Realists accept causation, whereas Mādhyamaka rejects it. B. Mādhyamaka accepts permanent substances, whereas realists reject them. C. Both use “real” and “empty” in exactly the same sense. D. Realists infer causal reality of conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamaka infers their lack of intrinsic nature.

Answer: D. Realists infer causal reality of conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamaka infers their lack of intrinsic nature.

Explanation: The positions partly answer different questions-whether phenomena function and whether they are self-grounded. A genuine dispute remains over whether momentary dharmas are ultimately real.

29. Which pramāṇas are fundamental for Dignāga and Dharmakīrti?

A. Perception and inference. B. Perception, inference and testimony. C. Perception, comparison, testimony and postulation. D. Six independent pramāṇas.

Answer: A. Perception and inference.

Explanation: Other apparently valid cognitions are reduced to these two. Perception concerns non-conceptual particulars; inference operates through conceptual construction.

30. Svalakṣaṇa is:

A. an eternal universal known by language. B. a unique causally efficient particular, the ultimate object of perception. C. the conventional person. D. the exclusion of non-cows.

Answer: B. A unique causally efficient particular, the ultimate object of perception.

Explanation: The momentary particular is directly efficacious and non-conceptual. A *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* is the generalized, conceptually constructed object used in thought and language.

31. Why is sāmānyalakṣaṇa associated with conceptual cognition?

A. It is an indivisible atom. B. It alone produces causal effects. C. It is a generalized construction rather than the unique particular given in bare perception. D. It is an eternal self.

Answer: C. It is a generalized construction rather than the unique particular given in bare perception.

Explanation: Concepts organize distinct particulars under repeatable types. Buddhist epistemologists deny that such universals exist as independently real entities.

32. Apoha explains word meaning primarily through:

A. direct contact with a real universal. B. divine assignment of meanings. C. resemblance to a permanent prototype. D. exclusion of what is other, such as “cow” functioning through exclusion of non-cows.

Answer: D. Exclusion of what is other, such as “cow” functioning through exclusion of non-cows.

Explanation: Because only unique particulars are ultimately real, repeatable linguistic classification cannot depend on eternal universals. Exclusion yields usable conceptual scope without reifying a universal.

33. Kumāṛila's major objection to Apoha is that:

A. purely negative exclusion seems unable to explain the positive unity grasped in a word's meaning. B. exclusion proves that universals are momentary. C. words never produce cognition. D. perception is always conceptual.

Answer: A. Purely negative exclusion seems unable to explain the positive unity grasped in a word's meaning.

Explanation: The Buddhist reply is that exclusions, grounded in causal similarities and practical purposes, generate a positive-seeming conceptual presentation without requiring a real universal.

34. In Buddhist epistemology, the contrast between *pramāṇa* and *pramāṇaphala* is best expressed as:

A. instrument and result must always be two enduring substances. B. a cognition can be the knowing operation in one aspect and its successful apprehension in another, unlike Nyāya's strongly external instrument-result model. C. valid cognition has no result. D. testimony alone joins the two.

Answer: B. A cognition can be the knowing operation in one aspect and its successful apprehension in another, unlike Nyāya's strongly external instrument-result model.

Explanation: Dignāga-Dharmakīrti resist multiplying separately enduring entities. The 2025 debate requires presenting this Buddhist reflexive or cognition-centred model against Nyāya's realist account.

35. Which is among the Buddha's *avyākṛta* questions?

A. Whether right action reduces suffering. B. Whether craving conditions clinging. C. Whether the world is eternal or non-eternal. D. Whether perception occurs.

Answer: C. Whether the world is eternal or non-eternal.

Explanation: Questions about the world's eternity/finitude, identity of soul and body, and the Tathāgata after death were left undeclared because their speculative framing did not conduce to liberation.

36. The best interpretation of the Buddha's silence on *avyākṛta* questions is:

A. proof that he secretly accepted every alternative. B. inability to reason about metaphysics. C. denial that language has any use. D. pragmatic and therapeutic refusal of wrongly framed speculation irrelevant to ending *duḥkha*.

Answer: D. Pragmatic and therapeutic refusal of wrongly framed speculation irrelevant to ending *duḥkha*.

Explanation: Silence is not automatically agnosticism or verificationism. It redirects inquiry toward causal conditions of suffering and may reject the presuppositions embedded in the alternatives.

37. The fire-going-out simile warns against asking where the liberated Tathāgata "goes" because:

A. "going somewhere" wrongly presupposes a substantial entity persisting independently of conditions. B. Nirvāṇa is a physical location. C. fire is an eternal substance. D. the Tathāgata becomes a creator.

Answer: A. "Going somewhere" wrongly presupposes a substantial entity persisting independently of conditions.

Explanation: When fuel ceases, fire is not properly described as travelling north or south. Likewise, post-mortem alternatives may import the substantial self that Buddhism rejects.

38. Which statement correctly relates the *Triratna* to *Nairātmyavāda*?

A. Refuge requires three eternal souls. B. Buddha and Saṅgha are conventionally real causal persons/communities, while Dhamma includes insight into no-self. C. No-self makes teaching and community impossible. D. Buddha is an unchanging creator.

Answer: B. Buddha and Saṅgha are conventionally real causal persons/communities, while Dhamma includes insight into no-self.

Explanation: Refuge is practical orientation within dependent relations, not interaction among immortal substances. Institutional and personal continuity need not be numerical identity.

39. Which pair correctly names the classical karmic objections?

A. *satkāryavāda* and *asatkāryavāda* B. *anyathākhyāti* and *akhyāti* C. *kṛtanāśa* (loss of the performed act) and *akṛtābhyāgama* (receipt of an unperformed result) D. *anvaya* and *vyatireka*

Answer: C. Kṛtanāśa (loss of the performed act) and akṛtābhyāgama (receipt of an unperformed result).

Explanation: Opponents argue that destruction of the agent loses desert, while a later different moment undeservedly receives the fruit. Buddhism replies through causal inheritance in one stream.

40. In a UPSC directive, “critically discuss” requires the candidate to:

A. define the doctrine and stop. B. reject the doctrine in advance. C. list scholars without argument. D. explain the position, present objections and replies, assess residual difficulties, and reach a reasoned verdict.

Answer: D. Explain the position, present objections and replies, assess residual difficulties, and reach a reasoned verdict.

Explanation: “Critically” does not mean hostile. A strong Philosophy answer follows claim -> named evidence or argument -> analysis -> qualification, then gives a proportionate conclusion.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

41. Which ordering of the middle nidānas is correct?

A. *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *sparśa* -> *vedanā* -> *trṣṇā* B. *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *trṣṇā* -> *vedanā* C. *vedanā* -> *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *trṣṇā* D. *trṣṇā* -> *vedanā* -> *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana*

Answer: A. Ṣaḍāyatana -> sparśa -> vedanā -> trṣṇā.

Explanation: The six sense bases condition contact, contact feeling and feeling craving. This sequence is both a factual requirement and the basis for explaining mindful interruption before craving.

42. Which school-pairing is correct?

A. Vaibhāṣika-external objects merely inferred; Sautrāntika-direct realism. B. Vaibhāṣika-direct realism; Sautrāntika-representational realism. C. Yogācāra-material atomism; Mādhyamaka-eternal consciousness. D. Sautrāntika-no external world; Yogācāra-direct realism.

Answer: B. Vaibhāṣika-direct realism; Sautrāntika-representational realism.

Explanation: Both are realist about external particulars, but they disagree about access. Yogācāra challenges independent externality, while Mādhyamaka empties both object and cognition of *svabhāva*.

43. Which statement avoids the most common Śūnyatā trap?

A. Empty phenomena cannot cause anything. B. Śūnyatā is an eternal metaphysical substance. C. Emptiness denies intrinsic nature while dependent conventional functioning remains. D. “Void” means absolute non-being.

Answer: C. Emptiness denies intrinsic nature while dependent conventional functioning remains.

Explanation: Nāgārjuna’s point is that dependence and emptiness are inseparable. Nihilism would destroy the very causal and linguistic practices through which the doctrine is expressed.

44. Which statement best answers the charge that ālaya-vijñāna is a disguised ātman?

A. It is permanent but should not be called a self. B. It belongs only to matter. C. It is outside causation and never changes. D. It is a conditioned, momentary and transformable stream carrying seeds, not an independent owner.

Answer: D. It is a conditioned, momentary and transformable stream carrying seeds, not an independent owner.

Explanation: Functional continuity alone does not equal substancehood. The objection revives if store-consciousness is incorrectly made immutable, unitary and self-established.

45. Which answer spine is best for “How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda?”

A. Define both -> derive impermanence from dependence -> add *arthakriyā* dilemma -> answer *sahakārin* -> explain *santāna* -> qualify the derivation. B. List twelve links -> state that everything changes -> conclude. C. Discuss only Nirvāṇa and no-self. D. Compare four Buddhist schools without showing any inference.

Answer: A. Define both -> derive impermanence from dependence -> add arthakriyā dilemma -> answer saḥakārin -> explain santāna -> qualify the derivation.

Explanation: The question tests derivation. A complete answer must expose the logical bridge and preserve continuity, not merely provide adjacent descriptions.

46. Which claim most accurately answers akṛtābhyāgama?

A. The later recipient is numerically identical in every respect to the earlier agent. B. The karmic fruit arises in the causally continuous stream shaped by the act, not in an unrelated series. C. Moral responsibility is an illusion. D. A creator reallocates karmic fruits.

Answer: B. The karmic fruit arises in the causally continuous stream shaped by the act, not in an unrelated series.

Explanation: Buddhism rejects both strict identity and absolute difference. The reply grounds desert in causal inheritance, though critics still question whether it fully explains ownership.

47. Which statement about Nirvāṇa and Kṣaṇikavāda is most precise?

A. Nirvāṇa is a permanent personal experience and therefore an exception to all Buddhist analysis. B. Nirvāṇa is momentary pleasure. C. Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities; Nirvāṇa may be described as unconditioned or as cessation, without postulating an eternal person. D. Momentariness logically rules out cessation.

Answer: C. Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities; Nirvāṇa may be described as unconditioned or as cessation, without postulating an eternal person.

Explanation: The compatibility depends on not substantializing Nirvāṇa. Finality means the non-renewal of suffering's conditions, not everlasting possession by an ego.

48. Which distinction is essential in answering the 2024 "everything is void/everything is real" PYQ?

A. Perception versus testimony. B. Buddha versus Saṅgha. C. Bodily continuity versus memory. D. Causal/conventional reality versus intrinsic or self-established reality.

Answer: D. Causal/conventional reality versus intrinsic or self-established reality.

Explanation: Realist schools affirm causally efficacious dharmas; Mādhyamaka denies their *svabhāva*. The distinction resolves superficial contradiction while retaining the deeper dispute about ultimate status.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 13 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Practice status: These are independently prepared learner models based on the verified UPSC questions in the repository. They are not official UPSC answer keys. Each answer should first be attempted under timed conditions and then used for comparison, correction and enrichment.

2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Explain the Mādhyamika inference from dependent origination to emptiness.
- Define *svabhāva* and show why dependence excludes it.
- Protect Śūnyatā from the charge of nihilism through the two truths.

Independent model answer

For Mādhyamika, *pratītyasamutpāda* means that every phenomenon arises only in dependence on causes, conditions, parts, relations and conceptual designation. Nāgārjuna uses this causal principle to deny *svabhāva*, an independent, self-established and invariant own-nature.

If a thing possessed *svabhāva*, it would exist through itself and would not await conditions. What depends upon conditions, however, is neither self-produced nor self-sufficient. Therefore:

dependent arising -> absence of independent own-nature -> ■■■nyat■

Śūnyatā consequently does not mean sheer non-being. A chariot, person or flame exists and functions conventionally, but none is discoverable as a self-grounded substance apart from its components and conditions. Indeed, causal efficacy is possible precisely because things are not fixed by immutable essence.

The doctrine of two truths blocks nihilism. At the level of *saṃvṛti-satya*, persons, causes, karma, language and compassion operate. At the level of *paramārtha-satya*, analysis finds no intrinsically existent entity. Even emptiness is empty: it is not a hidden Absolute but the absence of *svabhāva* in dependently designated things.

Thus Mādhyamika converts dependent origination into ontological anti-essentialism. "Whatever is dependently arisen is explained to be empty" affirms relational existence while rejecting independent essence.

Why this earns marks

- Gives the exact dependence-to-emptiness derivation.
- Defines *svabhāva* instead of treating Śūnyatā as a slogan.
- Uses a concrete conventional example.
- Employs the two truths against nihilism.
- Notes the "emptiness of emptiness" safeguard.

2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

- Test, rather than merely assert, the compatibility of no-self and liberation.
- Explain who practises and what ceases without postulating an eternal soul.
- Give reasons in favour while acknowledging the first-person identity objection.

Independent model answer

Nairātmyavāda denies a permanent, unitary and unchanging owner behind the five skandhas. *Nirvāṇa* is the cessation of ignorance, craving and the conditioned reproduction of suffering. They are consistent once liberation is understood as the transformation and cessation of a causal process, not as an eternal soul entering another substance or realm.

The empirical person is conventionally designated upon *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saṃjñā*, *saṃskāra* and *vijñāna*. Ignorance superimposes "I" and "mine" upon this changing aggregate-stream. That appropriation produces craving, clinging and renewed becoming:

self-grasping -> craving -> clinging -> becoming -> suffering

Insight into impermanence and no-self removes the cognitive basis of appropriation:

insight into no-self -> non-grasping -> cessation -> nirv■■■a

The objection is immediate: if no self exists, nobody suffers, practises or attains liberation. The Buddhist reply invokes *santāna*, causal continuity. The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Ethical discipline and meditative cultivation alter succeeding moments just as one flame conditions another without a single enduring flame-substance.

Theravāda descriptions emphasize cessation of greed, hatred and delusion and may classify Nirvāṇa as *asaṃskṛta*, unconditioned. Mahāyāna adds that saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa are both empty of *svabhāva*: their distinction concerns ignorance and insight, not two self-existent domains.

A residual difficulty remains. Causal continuity explains transmission, but critics ask whether it fully explains the first-person claim "I am liberated." Buddhism answers that this "I" is a conventional index within the stream, not evidence for an eternal ātman.

Therefore no-self is not an obstacle to Nirvāṇa; it is the insight that dissolves the grasping sustaining bondage.

Why this earns marks

- Defines both doctrines before testing consistency.
- Connects no-self directly to the causal production and cessation of *duḥkha*.
- Uses *santāna* to explain practice without a soul.
- Adds Theravāda-Mahāyāna nuance.
- States the strongest objection and offers a qualified verdict.

2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Present arguments, not merely translate *vijñaptimātratā* as “mind-only.”
- Explain how Yogācāra preserves ordered experience.
- Avoid reducing the school to arbitrary subjective imagination.

Independent model answer

Yogācāra advances *vijñaptimātratā*: what is immediately given is cognition-as-presentation, not an independently established external object standing outside every cognitive condition. The experienced division between subject and object is itself a construction within consciousness.

The dream argument shows that a coherent spatial world, objects and an experiencing subject can appear without corresponding external things. Therefore object-appearance alone cannot establish an independently existing material cause. Yogācāra also attacks atomism: an object cannot coherently be one indivisible atom, a mere heap of partless atoms, or a whole distinct from its parts. Further, if both object and cognition are momentary, the object allegedly known has already ceased when cognition arises; only its presented form is available.

This is not the claim that an individual ego invents the world at will. *Ālaya-vijñāna*, store-consciousness, carries karmic *bīja* whose maturation produces regular and coordinated experience. The *tri-svabhāva* clarifies the analysis: *parikalpita* is imagined subject-object duality; *paratantra* is the dependently arisen cognitive flow; *pariṇiṣpanna* is realization of that flow’s non-dual character.

Yogācāra therefore denies the external world as independently established, not causal order or disciplined experience. Its difficulty is whether common experience can be explained without covertly restoring an object-independent world.

Why this earns marks

- States *vijñaptimātratā* precisely.
- Uses dream, atom and temporal arguments.
- Explains order through *ālaya-vijñāna* and karmic seeds.
- Includes all three natures.
- Ends with a genuine philosophical difficulty.

2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Demand decoding

- Define dependent origination in general and existential forms.
- Show the logical bridge to *kṣaṇikavāda*.
- Include causal efficacy, apparent continuity and at least one objection.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda is conditional arising: “this being, that arises; from the cessation of this, that ceases.” Existentially it appears in the twelve nidānas from *avidyā* to *jarā-maraṇa*; philosophically it denies that conditioned phenomena arise independently, eternally or without causes.

The immediate consequence is impermanence. Whatever depends on a changing complex of conditions cannot remain wholly unchanged. Buddhist logicians strengthen this into universal momentariness through *arthakriyākāritva*, the criterion of causal efficacy:

1. What is real is capable of producing an effect.
2. A permanent entity possesses the same causal capacity at every moment.
3. It should therefore produce its effect always, all at once, or never.
4. If it acts only when auxiliary conditions arrive, the altered causal complex-not an unchanged substance-explains the effect.
5. Causal operation thus belongs to a determinate, moment-specific particular.
6. Hence, *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam*: whatever is causally real is momentary.

A seed, for example, is not one unchanged thing enduring through germination. It is a succession of causal phases, each producing a novel successor. Apparent endurance is *santāna*, a continuum of numerically distinct but causally connected events.

Nyāya objects that a permanent substance can possess stable power and act when *sahakārin* auxiliaries arrive. The Buddhist reply asks whether those auxiliaries alter the cause. If they do, strict permanence is abandoned; if they do not, the delayed effect remains unexplained.

Dependent origination by itself yields conditioned impermanence; joined to causal efficacy, it supports strict momentariness. Mādhyamika adds that momentary dharmas too are dependently arisen and must not be reified.

Why this earns marks

- Defines both the general formula and twelve-link context.
- Gives a stepwise *arthakriyā* proof.
- Explains continuity through *santāna*.
- Handles Nyāya's auxiliary-condition objection.
- Distinguishes impermanence from the stricter logical doctrine.

2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.

Demand decoding

- Establish a rigorous derivation rather than placing two doctrines side by side.
- Explain *arthakriyākāritva*, simultaneity/succession and *sahakārin*.
- Address continuity, objections and the Mādhyamika refinement.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda states that every conditioned phenomenon arises and ceases through a determinate complex of conditions. *Kṣaṇikavāda* radicalizes this into the thesis that every causally real conditioned entity exists for only a moment. The derivation proceeds through dependence, change and causal efficacy.

First, a self-existent permanent substance would not await conditions. Since conditioned phenomena arise only when causes converge and cease when those causes are absent, their existence is relational and alterable. Conditionality therefore excludes immutable self-subsistence.

Second, causal production marks a difference between phases. A seed capable of sprouting under one complex and no longer functioning as that seed after germination cannot be strictly identical before and after causal action. The effect is novel because the operative causal phase perishes in giving rise to its successor.

Third, Buddhist logicians formulate *arthakriyākāritva*: reality is capacity for effective causal operation. Suppose permanent X causes E. If X has its complete causal power, it should produce E immediately and, being unchanged, repeatedly or all effects simultaneously. If production is successive, X must have different operative powers at different times, contradicting permanence.

Nyāya answers that X waits for auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*). The Buddhist dilemma is: if auxiliaries add no new capacity, delay remains inexplicable; if they alter the causal capacity, the operative complex is no longer wholly

unchanged. Hence causal efficacy belongs to moment-specific particulars.

Momentariness does not entail disconnected flashes. *Santāna* is an ordered succession in which each moment transmits dispositions and causal powers to its successor. It explains the apparent continuity of flame, person, memory and karma without numerical identity. The later moment is neither identical with nor causally alien to the earlier one.

Two qualifications are needed. First, ordinary dependent origination directly establishes impermanence; strict one-moment duration depends on the additional arthakriyā argument. Second, Mādhyamika warns that momentary dharmas cannot replace permanent substances as new absolutes: because they too arise dependently, they are empty of *svabhāva*.

Thus Kṣaṇikavāda is a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda when conditional arising is interpreted through causal efficacy. Dependence removes permanence; arthakriyā locates reality in the perishing causal event; *santāna* preserves continuity.

Why this earns marks

- Builds the derivation in distinct logical stages.
- Uses the simultaneity/succession dilemma correctly.
- Engages Nyāya's named *sahakārin* reply.
- Explains continuity rather than confusing momentariness with chaos.
- Adds both the "extra premise" qualification and Mādhyamika correction.
- Concludes with a precise synthesis.

2020 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Demand decoding

- Name and explain the five aggregates.
- Distinguish conventional personhood from a substantial self.
- Explain liberation positively and answer the "who is liberated?" objection.

Independent model answer

Buddhism analyses the apparent self into five aggregates (*pañcaskandhas*): *rūpa* or material form; *vedanā* or feeling-tone; *saṃjñā* or recognition; *saṃskāra* or volitional formations; and *viññāna* or discriminative consciousness. Every candidate is conditioned, changing and not fully controllable. No permanent owner is found as one aggregate, their sum, or an entity outside them.

The *Milinda-pañha* chariot analogy expresses the positive position. "Chariot" is a conventional designation for suitably arranged parts; similarly, "person" names an organized psycho-physical causal stream. Buddhism therefore rejects an eternal ātman but not the conventional person who speaks, acts and undertakes discipline.

Liberation is *Nirvāṇa*: the cessation of *avidyā*, craving, clinging and the renewed production of *duḥkha*. The Noble Eightfold Path works upon the aggregate-stream. *Śīla* prevents harmful conditioning, *saṃādhi* disciplines attention and *prajñā* sees impermanence, suffering and no-self. Liberation is not the survival or annihilation of a soul; it is the ending of the processes that construct bondage.

The objection asks who receives the fruit if the practitioner constantly changes. Buddhism answers through *santāna*. The later liberated stream inherits the effects of earlier practice without being an unchanging substance. Causal continuity is sufficient for transformation just as education changes a child into an adult without requiring an immutable psychological core.

Thus aggregate analysis removes the imagined owner, while liberation removes the causes of appropriation. No-self is not a denial of the path's subject at the conventional level; it is its liberating insight.

Why this earns marks

- Correctly names and explains all five skandhas.

- Uses the chariot analogy without denying conventional persons.
- Defines Nirvāṇa through causal cessation and the Eightfold Path.
- Answers the agency/recipient objection with *santāna*.
- Avoids both eternalism and annihilationism.

2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Demand decoding

- Identify the precise object denied by each doctrine.
- Locate the distinction across early/Abhidharma and Mahāyāna tendencies.
- Explain why denying only the personal self may leave reified dharmas.

Independent model answer

Both doctrines express no-self, but their scope differs.

Doctrine	Object of denial	Positive implication	Typical emphasis
<i>Pudgala-nairātmya</i>	a permanent person or owner of the aggregates	person is conventionally designated upon a causal stream	broadly shared across Buddhism
<i>Dharma-nairātmya</i>	intrinsic self-nature in the constituent dharmas themselves	all phenomena are dependent and non-self-grounded	especially Mahāyāna

Pudgala-nairātmya analyses the person into the five skandhas and finds no independent *pudgala* as one of them, their sum or their possessor. It denies ātman while retaining conventional agency and causal continuity.

Some Abhidharma realist positions nevertheless treat momentary dharmas as ultimately real. *Dharma-nairātmya* extends the analysis: the supposed building blocks also lack *svabhāva*. Mādhyamika derives this from dependent origination; Yogācāra associates it with freedom from constructed subject-object duality.

The second doctrine prevents the critique of a substantial person from ending in a metaphysics of substantial atoms. Yet it does not mean that phenomena are nothing; it denies independent essence while preserving conventional causal functioning.

Why this earns marks

- Distinguishes the two doctrines by exact scope.
- Shows what remains conventionally valid.
- Locates Mahāyāna's extension without claiming earlier Buddhism accepted ātman.
- Explains the anti-reification purpose of *dharma-nairātmya*.
- Avoids equating emptiness with non-existence.

2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Explain the apparent contradiction between momentariness and memory.
- Present stream, trace/seed and Yogācāra mechanisms.
- Evaluate Nyāya's first-person ownership objection.

Independent model answer

Kṣaṇikavāda appears to make memory impossible. The moment that experienced an object has ceased before the remembering cognition arises; if the two moments are wholly different, how can the later one remember "I experienced this"?

Buddhism replaces substantial identity with *santāna*, a causally integrated continuum. An experience conditions its successor by leaving a disposition; the disposition is transmitted through later moments and, when suitable conditions arise, produces memory:

experience -> impression -> transmitted potency -> occasioning condition -> memory

Sautrāntika speaks of seeds or latent traces in the mental continuum. Yogācāra gives a more systematic account through *ālaya-vijñāna*, whose *bīja* preserve mnemonic and karmic potentials. Personal identity is therefore conventional continuity constituted by causal connection, bodily organization, resemblance, projects and inherited dispositions.

The later rememberer is neither strictly identical with nor wholly other than the earlier experiencer. Strict numerical identity would reintroduce an immutable ātman; absolute difference would generate the faults of lost action and unearned result. Buddhism adopts a middle relation of causal succession.

Nyāya's *pratyabhijñā* and memory objection remains powerful. Cognitions such as "this is that" and "I saw this" seem to presuppose one enduring subject that unifies past and present. Mere resemblance can explain similar content but perhaps not first-person ownership. The Buddhist replies that the "I" is itself a concept generated within an integrated stream: direct causal inheritance, not metaphysical substance, grounds appropriation.

This reply successfully explains information transmission and practical identity, much as ordinary law follows a changing person through time. Yet if first-person unity is regarded as irreducible, *santāna* may seem descriptive rather than fully explanatory.

Hence Buddhism offers a coherent process account of memory and identity, though the move from causal continuity to owned recollection remains philosophically contestable.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the exact temporal problem.
- Gives both Sautrāntika and Yogācāra continuity mechanisms.
- Uses the neither-identical-nor-wholly-different formula.
- Names Nyāya's recognition/ownership pressure.
- Distinguishes successful transmission from disputed first-person appropriation.

2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Reconcile delayed karmic fruit with the destruction of every moment.
- Name classical objections and school-specific Buddhist mechanisms.
- Critically test whether causation is enough for moral ownership.

Independent model answer

Karma connects intentional action with a later fruit; Kṣaṇikavāda denies any enduring agent that remains numerically identical from action to fruition. Their compatibility therefore depends on whether moral responsibility requires substance-identity or only appropriately ordered causal continuity.

Buddhism chooses the latter:

intention -> karmic impression/potency -> transmission in *santāna* -> maturation -> fruit

The act perishes, but not without causally modifying the stream. Sautrāntika explains the connection through seed-like potency; Yogācāra places karmic *bīja* in *ālaya-vijñāna*; Abhidharma traditions analyse multiple causal relations among successive dharmas. None requires an unchanging bearer.

Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta press three related objections. First, *kṛtanāśa*: because the doer perishes, the deed and its desert are lost. Second, *akṛtābhyāgama*: a later, numerically different moment receives the fruit of an act it did not perform. Third, praise, blame, recognition and remorse appear to presuppose one owner across time.

The Buddhist reply rejects the exhaustive choice between absolute identity and absolute difference. The fruit occurs in the very continuum causally formed by the action, not in an unrelated stream. A child and adult are neither qualitatively unchanged nor morally unrelated; responsibility normally tracks continuity of body, intention, memory and causal history rather than an empirically inaccessible ātman.

The objection that a momentary cause cannot yield a remote result is answered by serial transmission. Each moment immediately conditions the next, carrying transformed potency until supporting conditions permit maturation. A seed need not remain numerically present in the fruit; its causal influence persists through the series.

Nevertheless, two pressures remain. Causal explanation shows why B follows A more readily than why B's suffering is deserved as *my* fruit. Further, *ālaya-vijñāna* can appear to function like a disguised self if treated as a persistent substance. Yogācāra replies that the store-consciousness is itself momentary and transformable; Mādhyamaka adds that agent, act and fruit are conventionally dependent designations, not ultimate substances.

Karma and momentariness are therefore compatible within Buddhist process ontology. The account is strong against the demand for numerical identity, but its reduction of moral ownership to causal inheritance remains open to realist criticism.

Why this earns marks

- States the exact compatibility criterion.
- Explains Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Abhidharma mechanisms.
- Names *kṛtanāśa* and *akṛtābhyāgama* accurately.
- Answers both delayed fruition and personal ownership objections.
- Critically tests whether *ālaya-vijñāna* becomes a quasi-self.
- Ends with a balanced verdict rather than a doctrinal assertion.

2022 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoding

- Define Buddha, Dhamma and Saṅgha.
- Explain their internal, functional relation.
- Examine whether refuge, community and awakening require enduring selves.

Independent model answer

The *Triratna*-Buddha, Dhamma and Saṅgha-are the three refuges structuring Buddhist life. Buddha is the awakened teacher and exemplar; Dhamma is the truth of dependent origination, the diagnosis of suffering and the path to cessation; Saṅgha is the community that preserves, interprets and embodies that path.

Their relation is internal rather than additive. Buddha discovers and teaches Dhamma; Dhamma explains Buddha's awakening and makes its replication possible; Saṅgha transmits and practises Dhamma, producing further exemplars and sustaining access to the Buddha's teaching. Remove any one and the living refuge-system is impaired.

At first sight, *nairātmyavāda* creates inconsistency. Refuge seems to require a stable devotee, Buddha appears to be an enduring personal authority, and Saṅgha a collection of persons. Buddhism answers by distinguishing conventional personhood from an eternal ātman. Buddha is revered as an awakened causal continuum, not as creator or immortal soul. Saṅgha is a conventionally real community constituted by changing practitioners. Dhamma itself includes insight into no-self.

The two truths deepen this reply. Conventionally, teachers, vows, institutions and agents operate; ultimately, none possesses independent self-nature. No-self therefore regulates the meaning of refuge: it is practical orientation and transformative dependence, not surrender by one immortal substance to another.

A critic may reply that continuity of doctrine and authority still requires stable bearers. The Buddhist response is that transmission needs reliable causal and institutional continuity, not numerical identity. Manuscripts, practices and lineages persist as changing but connected series.

Thus Triratna and no-soul are consistent. Indeed, the three refuges provide the pedagogic and communal conditions through which attachment to substantial selfhood is overcome.

Why this earns marks

- Defines all three jewels.
- Shows their reciprocal functional relation.
- Distinguishes conventional agents from an eternal soul.
- Uses the two truths without making Saṅgha unreal.
- Addresses continuity of authority and ends with an integrative verdict.

2023 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Question: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.

Demand decoding

- Organize Buddhist soteriology around the quotation.
- Connect the Four Noble Truths, twelve nidānas and Eightfold Path.
- Explain why transformative knowledge, not mere information, brings cessation.

Independent model answer

Buddhist soteriology begins from the Four Noble Truths: duḥkha, its dependent origin, its cessation and the path. The quotation condenses this structure. Ignorance of dependent origination is not a mere absence of theoretical information; *avidyā* is the practical misperception of conditioned, impermanent and selfless processes as permanent, satisfactory and owned by an "I."

The twelve nidānas display suffering as a conditioned circuit:

avidyā → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → āyatanā → sparśa → vedanā →
tattva → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-maraṇa

Ignorance conditions formations and an appropriative mode of consciousness. Contact and feeling become craving; craving becomes clinging and renewed becoming. Thus suffering is not imposed by fate or God. It is continuously produced when supporting conditions operate.

Knowledge of dependent origination discloses three features: impermanence, absence of autonomous essence, and the interruptibility of causal processes. Feeling need not become craving; craving need not become clinging. Wisdom removes the false owner, while disciplined conduct and meditation transform the conditions under which reactions arise.

The Noble Eightfold Path embodies this knowledge. *Prajñā*-right view and resolve-understands dependence and no-self. *Śīla*-right speech, action and livelihood-prevents fresh harmful conditioning. *Samādhi*-right effort, mindfulness and concentration-reveals feeling before it hardens into craving and stabilizes non-grasping awareness.

Different schools refine the same soteriological grammar. Abhidharma analyses the stream into conditioned dharmas; Yogācāra purifies karmic seeds and the subject-object construction; Mādhyamaka realizes that dependently originated phenomena are empty of *svabhāva*, preventing attachment even to dharmas, doctrine or Nirvāṇa.

The statement should not be intellectualized. One may recite the twelve links while continuing to crave. Liberating knowledge is cultivated insight that restructures perception, affect and conduct. Nor does cessation imply annihilation of a self; it is cessation of the conditions reproducing duḥkha.

Therefore ignorance is suffering because it sustains appropriation within the dependent chain. Knowledge is cessation when it becomes the lived path by which those conditions are understood, weakened and finally extinguished.

Why this earns marks

- Makes the quotation the organizing thesis.
- Integrates Four Noble Truths, all twelve links and the Eightfold Path.
- Identifies practical intervention at feeling-craving-clinging.
- Adds Abhidharma, Yogācāra and Mādhyamaka nuances.

- Distinguishes transformative wisdom from verbal knowledge.
- Explains cessation without annihilationism.

2024 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely “everything is void” and “everything is real” from the same doctrine of *Pratītyasamutpāda*? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoding

- Identify the realist and emptiness-oriented schools.
- Show how the same premise yields different conclusions.
- Distinguish causal reality from intrinsic reality without erasing disagreement.

Independent model answer

The apparent opposition arises because Buddhist schools ask different ontological questions of *pratītyasamutpāda*.

For Vaibhāṣika-and, with an epistemic qualification, Sautrāntika-dependent origination confirms the reality of conditioned dharmas. What enters causal relations and performs *arthakriyā* cannot be sheer illusion. Vaibhāṣika treats external momentary dharmas as directly perceived; Sautrāntika accepts external particulars but holds that they are known inferentially through mental representations. “Everything is real” therefore means that causally efficacious conditioned particulars are real, not that they are permanent substances.

Mādhyamika draws a different inference. Whatever arises only through causes and conditions lacks independent *svabhāva*. To possess own-nature would be to exist self-sufficiently and not dependently. Therefore all dharmas are *śūnya*. “Everything is void” means empty of intrinsic nature, not non-existent or causally inert.

Shared premise	Realist conclusion	Mādhyamika conclusion
phenomena arise through conditions	causal efficacy establishes conditioned reality	dependence disproves self-existence
permanent substance is rejected	momentary dharmas remain ultimately real	even momentary dharmas lack <i>svabhāva</i>
ordinary causation works	because real particulars interact	because conventionally designated relations function

The opposition is partly verbal: “real” answers whether phenomena causally function, while “void” answers whether they are intrinsically grounded. Yet a genuine dispute remains. Abhidharma realism grants ultimate status to basic dharmas; Mādhyamika argues that doing so arrests analysis too early and reifies the conditioned.

The two truths preserve the Mādhyamika position from nihilism: causation and karma operate conventionally, while ultimately no entity is self-established. Thus the same doctrine supports realism about dependent functioning and emptiness regarding independent essence.

Why this earns marks

- Correctly identifies Vaibhāṣika/Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika.
- Derives both conclusions from one premise.
- Distinguishes direct from representational realism.
- Separates causal efficacy from *svabhāva*.
- Preserves both partial reconciliation and genuine doctrinal disagreement.

2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Test Nirvāṇa separately against momentariness and no-self.
- Address conditioned/unconditioned and “who attains?” objections.
- Include a Mādhyamika qualification and a balanced verdict.

Independent model answer

Nirvāṇa is consonant with Kṣaṇikavāda and Nairātmyavāda if it is understood as cessation of the causes of suffering, not as an eternal soul entering a permanent condition.

Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities: whatever arises through causes is momentary. This makes cessation intelligible, for a conditioned series continues only while its supports remain. Through the path, ignorance, craving and clinging cease to condition renewed becoming. Some traditions describe Nirvāṇa as *asaṃskṛta*, unconditioned; others emphasize the event or fact of cessation rather than a positive timeless substance.

Nairātmyavāda likewise poses no necessary contradiction. The person who practises is a conventional aggregate-stream. Earlier discipline causally transforms later moments; no immutable owner is needed. Nirvāṇa is neither the immortality nor the destruction of an ātman, because no such entity was admitted.

Opponents formulate a dilemma. If Nirvāṇa is permanent and real, does it violate momentariness? If momentary, how can liberation be final? If there is no self, who attains it? Buddhism replies that finality means non-renewal of the relevant conditions, not everlasting endurance of a personal state. Kṣaṇikavāda governs produced dharmas, while cessation is not another produced ego-experience.

Mādhyamika adds an anti-reification safeguard. Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa are both empty of *svabhāva*; they are not two independent realms. Their distinction concerns bondage through ignorance and freedom through insight at the conventional level.

Tension remains where Nirvāṇa is treated as a positively existent eternal entity, or where first-person liberation is assumed to require numerical identity. Process interpretations avoid both assumptions, though critics may find them too deflationary.

Therefore the three doctrines are broadly consonant: momentariness explains the cessability of conditioned suffering, and no-self removes the grasping that sustains it. Consistency depends on refusing to substantialize either the liberated person or Nirvāṇa.

Why this earns marks

- Tests both requested doctrines independently.
- Distinguishes conditioned momentariness from unconditioned cessation.
- Answers the permanent/momentary and “who attains?” dilemmas.
- Adds the Mādhyamika non-reification account.
- Identifies the precise interpretive condition of compatibility.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why Pratītyasamutpāda is simultaneously a theory of causation and a method of liberation.

Demand decoding

- Establish the unity of explanatory and soteriological functions.
- Identify how the causal chain can be interrupted.
- Avoid treating dependent origination as neutral cosmology.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda states that conditioned events arise and cease with their supporting conditions. It is therefore a theory of causation: duḥkha is neither accidental nor divinely imposed, but produced through an intelligible sequence of ignorance, formations, feeling, craving, clinging and becoming.

The same principle is a method of liberation because conditions are alterable. The chain is not fate:

contact -> feeling -> craving -> clinging -> becoming

Mindfulness can disclose feeling before it becomes craving; wisdom sees the experience as impermanent and non-self; ethical discipline prevents fresh harmful conditioning. When ignorance and craving cease, the dependent production of suffering also ceases.

The Four Noble Truths express this unity. The second truth diagnoses conditioned origin; the third affirms cessation; the fourth prescribes the practices that transform the conditions. Knowledge must therefore be practical and cultivated, not merely verbal.

Verdict: Pratītyasamutpāda is liberating precisely because it is causal. By explaining how suffering is made, it shows how suffering can be unmade.

Why this earns marks

- Answers both halves through one principle.
- Identifies a concrete intervention point.
- Links the doctrine with the Four Noble Truths.
- Distinguishes transformative from merely propositional knowledge.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish the Buddhist denial of ātman from the denial of causal and conventional personhood.

Demand decoding

- Prevent the common inference from no-self to no person or no responsibility.
- Use aggregates, designation and *santāna*.
- State the residual philosophical issue briefly.

Independent model answer

Nairātmyavāda denies an eternal, unitary and independently existing ātman; it does not deny every legitimate use of “person.” Aggregate analysis finds only *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saṃjñā*, *saṃskāra* and *vijñāna*, none of which is permanent or an owner of the rest.

The chariot analogy shows the positive account. A chariot is designated upon organized parts; a person is designated upon an organized psycho-physical stream. This conventional person acts, remembers, undertakes the path and bears consequences.

Causal continuity is explained through *santāna*. An earlier intention modifies succeeding moments, so the later recipient is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier agent. No-self therefore rejects substance-identity, not continuity, agency or moral practice.

The main objection is that causal connection may not fully explain first-person ownership-why a later memory or karmic fruit is *mine*. Buddhism replies that “mine” is itself constructed within the integrated stream.

Verdict: Buddhist no-self is a revision of personal identity from substance to dependent process, not the elimination of practical personhood.

Why this earns marks

- States exactly what is denied and retained.
- Uses both five-skandha analysis and the chariot analogy.
- Explains responsibility through *santāna*.
- Includes a concise critical qualification.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Mādhyamaka as four answers to the problem of the object of knowledge.

Demand decoding

- Compare all four schools on one epistemic-ontological axis.
- Show the movement from direct object to critique of both object and consciousness.
- Give strengths, pressures and a qualified verdict.

Independent model answer

The four schools offer progressively different answers to what cognition knows and what status its object possesses.

School	Object position	Mode of access	Main pressure
Vaibhāṣika	external momentary dharmas are real	directly perceived	how can a momentary object be simultaneously present to cognition?
Sautrāntika	external particulars are real	inferred from mental representations	how can a known representation prove an unknown original?
Yogācāra	independently external object is unestablished	cognition presents both subject and object	how is intersubjective order explained?
Mādhyamaka	both mind and object lack <i>svabhāva</i>	knowledge operates conventionally	does universal emptiness undermine its own claim?

Vaibhāṣika protects common-sense causal realism: perception reaches real external dharmas. Sautrāntika recognizes temporal and cognitive mediation; the directly given item is a mental form whose external cause is inferred.

Yogācāra radicalizes the problem through *vijñaptimātratā*. Dream and atom arguments challenge an object existing independently of presentation. *Ālaya-vijñāna* and karmic seeds explain ordered experience; this is not arbitrary private imagination.

Mādhyamaka then warns that making consciousness ultimate merely shifts reification from object to subject. Because both arise dependently, neither has self-established nature. The two truths preserve conventional inquiry while ultimate analysis removes intrinsic essence.

The sequence is not a simple historical ladder. Vaibhāṣika best protects direct causal realism; Sautrāntika explains mediation; Yogācāra exposes cognitive construction; Mādhyamaka gives the widest anti-essentialist critique. Each solves one pressure by creating another.

Verdict: The debate moves from “Which object is known?” to “Can knower or known be intrinsically grounded?” Mādhyamaka is the most radical answer, but it remains viable only if conventional truth genuinely supports knowledge and argument.

Why this earns marks

- Compares all four schools through a common matrix.
- Preserves direct versus representational realism.
- Explains rather than caricatures *vijñaptimātratā*.
- Shows why Mādhyamaka also empties consciousness.
- Evaluates each position and reaches a qualified verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Does the Buddhist theory of Apoha successfully explain general words without admitting real universals? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- State why Buddhist nominalism needs Apoha.
- Present its mechanism, named objection and Buddhist reply.
- Assess semantic success separately from ontological economy.

Independent model answer

Dignāga and Dharmakīrti distinguish the unique, causally efficient *svalakṣaṇa* from the generalized *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* constructed by thought. If only momentary particulars are ultimately real, a word such as “cow” cannot refer to one eternal universal present in many individuals. Apoha explains its extension through “exclusion of the other”: “cow” applies by excluding non-cows.

The theory is not bare negation. Repeated encounters generate dispositions; relevant causal similarities and human purposes stabilize a field of exclusions. These exclusions produce a positive-seeming conceptual presentation adequate for recognition, inference and communication, without postulating an independently existing cow-universal.

Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara object that exclusion presupposes what it seeks to explain. To know “non-cow,” one must already know cow; moreover, a merely negative operation seems unable to yield the positive unity conveyed by

a word. Different non-cows are indefinitely many, so their exclusion appears cognitively cumbersome.

The Buddhist reply distinguishes causal acquisition from philosophical analysis. Linguistic competence develops through practices of differentiation, not prior apprehension of a metaphysical universal. Mutual exclusions can generate a stable conceptual image, and practical success-not correspondence with an eternal entity-is the test of semantic adequacy.

Yet the objection is not fully dissolved. Apoha economically explains classification without realism about universals, but the positive phenomenology of meaning may be redescribed rather than completely derived from negation.

Verdict: Apoha is ontologically parsimonious and pragmatically powerful. Its weakness lies less in reference to particulars than in explaining how differential exclusion acquires the experienced positive unity of a concept.

Why this earns marks

- Grounds Apoha in the *svalakṣaṇa-sāmānyalakṣaṇa* distinction.
- Gives a clear example.
- Names Kumāṛila and Uddyotakara's objections.
- Presents the Buddhist practice-and-exclusion reply.
- Separates ontological economy from semantic completeness.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Buddhist process ontology secures change more successfully than it secures moral responsibility." Critically examine.

Demand decoding

- Test both parts of the proposition.
- Use dependent origination, momentariness, no-self and school-specific continuity devices.
- Assess whether causal succession can ground ownership and desert.

Independent model answer

Buddhist process ontology replaces enduring substance with dependent events. Its account of change is powerful because change is no longer an accidental modification of something fundamentally immutable; it is the very mode of conditioned existence.

Pratītyasamutpāda explains novelty through changing causal complexes. Kṣaṇikavāda sharpens this through *arthakriyākāritva*: the real is what performs a causal function, and a wholly permanent entity cannot explain delayed or successive effects. Nairātmyavāda extends the process model to persons, analysing them into changing skandhas rather than an invariant owner. The flame and seed series show how ordered transformation requires continuity but not numerical sameness.

Moral responsibility is harder. Karma connects an intention with a later fruit, but the acting moment has perished. Buddhism answers through *santāna*:

intention -> impression/potency -> serial transmission -> maturation -> fruit

Sautrāntika speaks of seeds in the continuum; Yogācāra uses *ālaya-vijñāna*; Abhidharma maps causal relations among dharmas. The later recipient is neither identical with nor unrelated to the earlier agent.

This answer defeats a crude objection. Ordinary responsibility already survives major bodily and psychological change. A mature adult may answer for a childhood promise because causal history, memory, intention and social continuity connect the phases. Numerical identity of an unobservable soul appears unnecessary.

Opponents nevertheless formulate *kṛtanāśa*: the destroyed doer loses the deed, and *akṛtābhyāgama*: a different successor receives an unperformed result. Nyāya adds that remorse and "I did this" contain first-person ownership that resemblance and succession do not explain. Causal continuity tells us why B follows A, but perhaps not why B deserves A's fruit.

The Buddhist reply is that desert supervenes on intentional causal inheritance within one stream. The "owner" adds no explanatory work unless its interaction with changing mental states is shown. Mādhyamaka further treats agent, act and fruit as conventionally dependent; morality needs stable practices, not ultimate substances.

Still, two risks remain. *Ālaya-vijñāna* may look like a quasi-self if reified, and reducing ownership to causal linkage may not satisfy those who regard first-person unity as irreducible. Yogācāra answers the first by making store-consciousness momentary and transformable; the second remains a genuine philosophical dispute.

Verdict: Buddhism explains change more naturally than substance theories because causal novelty is basic rather than derivative. Its account of responsibility is coherent and practically adequate, but less decisive: causal inheritance plausibly grounds accountability, yet the transition from succession to first-person moral ownership remains contested.

Why this earns marks

- Evaluates both change and responsibility rather than discussing karma alone.
- Integrates Pratītyasamutpāda, *arthakriyā*, no-self and *santāna*.
- Uses Sautrāntika, Yogācāra, Abhidharma and Mādhyamaka refinements.
- Names and answers *kṛtanāśa* and *akṛtābhyāgama*.
- Distinguishes causal transmission from moral ownership.
- Ends with a measured, examiner-grade verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism only by preserving the authority of conventional truth.” Examine with reference to Pratītyasamutpāda, the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

Demand decoding

- Explain why Śūnyatā attracts the nihilism charge.
- Show how dependence, two truths and reflexive emptiness answer it.
- Test whether conventional truth is merely expedient or philosophically indispensable.

Independent model answer

Mādhyamaka holds that all phenomena are empty of *svabhāva*. The charge of nihilism arises because, if nothing possesses intrinsic nature, causation, knowledge, ethics and liberation may seem impossible. Nāgārjuna’s answer is not to dilute emptiness but to show that conventional truth is the very field in which empty phenomena function.

Pratītyasamutpāda provides the first defence. A cause produces an effect only through relations and changing conditions. If either possessed fixed, independent own-nature, genuine interaction and transformation would be unintelligible. Emptiness therefore does not negate causation; it explains its possibility:

dependence -> absence of self-establishment -> relational efficacy

The two truths articulate this insight. At *saṃvṛti-satya*, persons deliberate, words refer, reasons support conclusions, karma bears fruit and the path ends suffering. At *paramārtha-satya*, analysis finds no independently existing agent, word, reason or dharma. Ultimate truth is not a second world behind convention; it is the absence of intrinsic nature in the conventional world.

The nihilist objection may persist: if conventional truth is itself empty, why trust it? Mādhyamaka replies that validity need not mean self-grounding. A map can guide without containing an intrinsic “map essence”; similarly, conventions are evaluated through coherence, dependence and practical success. The distinction between valid convention and hallucination remains internal to causal practices.

“Emptiness of emptiness” supplies the reflexive safeguard. Śūnyatā is not an Absolute that survives the deconstruction of all else. It too is dependently designated as a corrective to reification. Once its therapeutic work is done, it cannot be grasped as a metaphysical foundation.

Realists such as Nyāya object that this position borrows logic and causation while denying the stable entities required for them. If every thesis is empty, the thesis of emptiness appears self-refuting. Mādhyamaka answers that argument does not require intrinsically existent premises; conventional relations of entailment suffice. The critique targets the opponent’s claim of self-existence without proposing a rival essence.

However, conventional truth is not a dispensable ladder. Without its authority, there could be no teaching of emptiness, differentiation of wholesome from unwholesome, or path to Nirvāṇa. Mādhyamaka must therefore preserve a robust, though non-ultimate, account of warranted convention. If “conventional” is reduced to whatever appears, nihilism returns.

Verdict: Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism because emptiness and convention are mutually dependent: emptiness prevents reification, while convention preserves causation, rational assessment and liberation. The emptiness of emptiness completes the anti-essentialist logic, but the school's success depends upon making conventional validity more than mere illusion.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the strongest nihilist and self-refutation objections.
- Derives emptiness from dependent origination.
- Explains both truths without turning them into two worlds.
- Uses "emptiness of emptiness" as a reflexive safeguard.
- Shows why conventional standards remain indispensable.
- Gives a qualified verdict identifying the doctrine's precise burden.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Layer-placement note

All Layer 3 material from the legacy complete session is retained here after practice. It should refine a core answer, not displace the printed syllabus.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced derivation and school divergence

Dependent origination is not a search for the universe's first cause. It diagnoses the structure of conditioned becoming here and now. This avoids eternalism because no unchanged self grounds the process, and avoids annihilationism because causal continuity remains.

The doctrine supports different ontological conclusions. Mādhyamika argues that whatever depends on conditions lacks *svabhāva* and is therefore empty. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika instead emphasise that causally functioning conditioned events are real. Their disagreement concerns ultimate status, not whether dependent arising occurs.

The strongest challenge is regress: if every event is conditioned, what explains the chain as a whole? The Buddhist reply is therapeutic and structural rather than foundational-the task is to identify and cease the conditions of suffering, not posit an unconditioned creator-substance.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced argument and Nyāya pressure

The causal-efficiency argument asks how a wholly permanent cause could produce effects at different times. If its complete power operates immediately, all effects should appear together; if it produces successively, its causal profile changes and it is not wholly permanent. Auxiliary conditions do not automatically save permanence: if they make the decisive difference, the unchanged cause appears redundant.

Nyāya's reply remains powerful. An enduring substance may act when the required conditions arrive, while recognition-"this is that"-memory and moral ownership seem to presuppose numerical identity. Buddhism answers with similarity, causal transmission, seeds and, in Yogācāra, *ālaya-vijñāna*.

The residual issue is ownership. A stream can transmit information and karmic effects, but critics ask what makes it *one person's* stream rather than merely a sequence externally described as one.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced compatibility problem

The chariot analogy shows that a person is designated upon organised components and relations; no separate chariot-substance or person-substance must be added. Early Buddhism primarily denies *pudgala-ātman*, while Mahāyāna extends emptiness to dharmas themselves.

Karma without self avoids both strict identity and complete difference: the later recipient is neither numerically identical to nor causally disconnected from the earlier agent. This middle position preserves transmission but remains vulnerable to the moral-ownership objection.

Nirvāṇa is not the immortality of an ego and not the destruction of an eternal person. It is cessation of greed, hatred, delusion and the conditioned production of suffering. Theravāda may distinguish the unconditioned from momentary conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamika avoids reifying nirvāṇa as a separate substance by reading saṃsāra and nirvāṇa through emptiness.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced distinctions and anti-nihilist safeguards

Yogācāra should not be equated casually with Advaita. Its *ālaya-vijñāna* is a conditioned stream carrying seeds, not an eternal Brahman or creator consciousness. The three natures distinguish imagined duality, dependent cognitive process and the perfected absence of that duality.

Mādhyamika's *catuṣkoṭi* is a dialectical test of reified alternatives, not a licence to assert contradictions. The two truths preserve conventional causation and practice while denying intrinsic nature ultimately. "Emptiness of emptiness" blocks the transformation of *śūnyatā* into a new Absolute.

Buddhist criticism of a creator stresses explanatory redundancy, the incompatibility of immutable agency with temporal action, and the moral problem of suffering. Dependent origination supplies a non-theistic causal alternative without claiming that events are uncaused.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced dialectical verdict

Nyāya's recognition and memory objections target ownership rather than mere transmission. Buddhist stream theories explain how traces continue, but the critic asks who recognises or deserves. Mīmāṃsā adds a semantic challenge: *apoha* may explain exclusion but appears to presuppose positive similarity.

Advaita criticism presses the soteriological cost of emptiness and momentariness. The Buddhist response distinguishes conventional path and ultimate non-reification; liberation is transformation and cessation within the process, not discovery of an eternal witness.

Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject a transcendent self, but Cārvāka identifies the person with the conscious body while Buddhism analyses body and mind into a causal aggregate-stream. The disagreement is therefore material identity versus process ontology.

A balanced verdict concedes that Buddhism offers a sophisticated non-substantialist model while leaving a real philosophical burden concerning first-person unity and moral ownership.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced control of terminology

Technical vocabulary should mark distinctions, not decorate prose. *Anitya* is general impermanence; *kṣaṇikavāda* is the radical scholastic claim of momentariness. *Śūnyatā* denies *svabhāva*, not conventional causation. *Nairātmyavāda* denies permanent selfhood, not the pragmatic designation of persons.

The restored doctrine material also prevents a narrow syllabus reading. Pañcaskandhas, liberation, Buddhist epistemology and the four schools explain how the three headline doctrines actually function.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced epistemic and pragmatic issues

The two-pramāṇa theory aligns epistemology with momentariness: only the unique causally effective particular is ultimately real, while universals are conceptual. *Apoha* avoids eternal universals by explaining "cow" through exclusion of non-cows, but opponents ask how exclusion works without some positive basis of similarity.

The relation between *pramāṇa* and *pramāṇaphala* reflects a process model of cognition rather than Nyāya's sharply separated instrument and result. This is a high-value cross-school comparison.

The Buddha's silence on undeclared questions is pragmatic, not mere ignorance. The poisoned-arrow reasoning asks whether speculation conduces to cessation. The danger is anti-intellectualism; the defence is disciplined relevance. The silence rejects metaphysical fixation without denying that causal and ethical analysis is possible.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced synthesis

Buddhism's greatest strength is the integration of metaphysics and therapy. Dependent origination explains why suffering arises and how it can cease; momentariness and no-self prevent reification; the schools then debate how much reality, consciousness or emptiness the process requires.

Its central philosophical risk is that causal continuity may not fully replace first-person unity, recognition and moral ownership. Madhyamaka adds a second risk: anti-essentialist language can look self-refuting unless the two truths and emptiness of emptiness are stated clearly.

The defensible verdict is neither "Buddhism denies reality" nor "Buddhism is modern science." It is a rigorous anti-substantialist and soteriological process philosophy whose internal variants range from realism to idealist analysis and radical emptiness.

LINK: **Current conceptual anchor:** the February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition in Colombo, officially documented by the High Commission of India, illustrates Buddhist heritage as cultural diplomacy. It is contextual evidence only, never proof of doctrine.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. System identity

- Printed syllabus: schools of Buddhism; dependent origination; momentariness; no-self.
- Four Noble Truths provide the existential frame.
- Doctrine is diagnostic and soteriological, not merely speculative.
- Main school spectrum: Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Mādhyamika.

B. Dependent origination

- "This being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases."
- Twelve links run from ignorance to ageing and death.
- It rejects both eternalism and annihilationism.
- Conditioned suffering is removable because its sustaining conditions can cease.

C. Derivation spine

DEPENDENT ARISING

- > no independent self-grounding
- > impermanence
- > momentariness of the causally real
- > no permanent owner behind the aggregates
- Mādhyamika further derives emptiness of *svabhāva*.
- Realist schools instead stress the reality of conditioned dharmas.

D. Momentariness

- *Arthakriyākāritva*: the real performs a causal function.
- A wholly permanent cause should act always or never.
- Successive causal action implies different moment-specific capacities.
- Apparent endurance is a causally connected *santāna*.

E. No-self

- The person is designated on five aggregates: form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness.
- Person-no-self denies a permanent subject.
- Dharma-no-self denies intrinsic nature in phenomena.
- No-self removes grasping; it does not abolish causal continuity or conventional agency.

F. Karma, memory and nirvāṇa

- Karma requires continuity, not numerical identity of substance.
- Memory tracks a causally connected stream, though ownership remains a pressure point.
- Nirvāṇa is cessation of ignorance, craving and suffering-producing conditions.
- No-self and nirvāṇa are compatible because liberation transforms a stream rather than frees an eternal soul.

G. Four schools

School	External world	Cognition	Signature
Vaibhāṣika	real, directly perceived	direct realism	real dharmas
Sautrāntika	real, inferred	representational realism	momentary external causes
Yogācāra	not independently established	cognition-only	<i>vijñaptimātratā</i>
Mādhyamika	conventionally functional	no intrinsic entities	<i>śūnyatā</i>

H. Yogācāra

- Dream and atom arguments challenge independently established external objects.
- *Ālayavijñāna* carries karmic seeds and explains ordered experience.
- Three natures: imagined, dependent and perfected.
- Mind-only is not arbitrary private fantasy; it is a structured causal account of cognition.

I. Mādhyamika

- What arises dependently lacks self-existent *svabhāva*.
- Emptiness is not non-being; conventional causation and language remain operative.
- Two truths: conventional and ultimate.
- Emptiness is itself empty and must not become a new Absolute.

J. Epistemology and silence

- Dignāga-Dharmakīrti recognize perception and inference.
- Perception grasps the unique particular; concepts work through exclusion (*apoha*).
- *Pramāṇaphala* links valid cognition and its result.
- Silence on *avyākṛta* questions is pragmatic: irrelevant speculation does not end suffering.

K. Criticism-reply grid

Pressure	Buddhist reply	Residual issue
no self, no responsibility	causal stream transmits consequences	moral ownership
momentariness blocks memory	later moments inherit traces	first-person identity
emptiness is nihilism	two truths preserve convention	self-reference
Yogācāra becomes solipsism	karmic seeds explain ordered experience	intersubjectivity
permanence can await auxiliaries	changed causal complex does the work	status of enduring powers

L. Final answer discipline

1. Start from the exact doctrine and define the key Sanskrit term.
2. Show the derivation rather than merely list conclusions.
3. Distinguish causal continuity from substantial identity.
4. Identify the school before attributing realism, mind-only or emptiness.
5. State one serious objection and the strongest Buddhist reply.
6. Preserve the difference between conventional reality and intrinsic nature.
7. Conclude with a graded soteriological and philosophical verdict.

Final judgement: Buddhism tightly connects causation, metaphysics and liberation. Its strength is an anti-essentialist process account of suffering; its hardest problems concern identity, moral ownership, intersubjectivity and the non-nihilistic articulation of emptiness.